

Zone 3032

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Preface

Dear reader, hopefully you enjoy my book as much as I did writing it. Ever since I started writing Zone 3032, I have enjoyed reading it. Hopefully, this book is enjoyable for you. Before you continue to read on, I wish to make known the mission of this book. I don't have any plans on making another sequel (not like anybody asked), and I did not add a real deep meaning to the book. I just wrote a story that could (in my mind) happen in real life. Through the writing of this book, you have been confused by some of the terms; if so, please consider looking at the Glossary in the back, which should help a little. Enjoy

Acknowledgements

Special thanks to... Dad, for his thoughtful responses to my simple questions, Abi, for editing it—how this book might have been made without help, I don't know—and my friends who gave me honest and good feedback. This book would be very different without your help.

Chapter 1

A fresh start.

Kushnov had always entertained the idea of being a pure modern-day mountain man, though he never knew why. He thought that if he could combine his two favorite things, the unknown and the outdoors, then he would be able to truly understand what natural instincts still were inside today's modern, soft man.

Kushnov was Russian by birth, but was a US citizen because his parents had moved out of Russia because of the danger of living in Russia. They moved to Washington State because of the danger of anomalies in Russia, since they were becoming an ever-increasing problem there. Kushnov was only about 3 months old when his parents moved, and that was 21 years ago. Even though he had been in America for almost all of his life, he was only comfortable when he was in the wilderness or the dark tunnels and bunkers that littered the state of Washington.

He only had two friends, Kyle and Alex. Kyle was the thinker of their friend group, he was the one who was most willing to put the time into understanding science and the natural world. He was also a problem solver, and he spent much of his time learning. He was from Germany, and his parents wanted to move to America because of the job his dad was offered, which was to be a lead researcher in stealth aircraft technology. Alex was the best at talking to people; he knew how to think the way his opponent did and understood the motives of the people around him. He was Polish by birth. Although his dad was an American, his mom was from Poland, and they lived in Poland until Alex was 3.

These friends were all within three years of age, and they understood how to work well together. They were a well-educated trio and always were willing to learn from or listen to older people, unlike their peers. One day, at Kyle's house, they were trying to get their plans in order so that they could go on a backpacking trip to the mountains for a few days, and they planned on bringing nothing more than the necessities. As the young adults went over their list, Kyle's dad made a comment that stopped them in their planning.

"It's a shame you don't have any anomalous things to keep you up at night." He said. "I was reading a news article that my work sent out to all its workers as a sort of 'newsletter' if you wish. They are looking for some people who would be interested

in taking part in a research project that would include camping, and since I was dumb enough to tell them that my son and his friends were great at learning, they won't leave me alone! Would you consider doing some work for them?"

The statement, although random, was something that could open the door for them all to get some true experience on something, and they were not going to pass down a job that they could get paid for doing (jobs were hard to come by).

So they contacted Kyle's dad's workplace and told them that they were willing to come. They were told that all they needed was their own clothes and an ID. They booked a flight to Alaska, and after getting off the airplane, there they were greeted by a man in a uniform wearing glasses who looked to be about thirty or forty.

"Are you the 3 trainees?" he asked.

"Yes sir." said Alex.

"Well then, did you check any baggage?"

"No, we only have carry-ons," said Kushnov. "Since we were told to bring very little."

"Great," The man said. "Then let's get to the van."

As they walked out of the airport, Kushnov noticed that the man didn't have a phone, or

any electronic device for that matter. "Odd," he thought.

As they got to the main doors of the airport, they saw a huge black van. They were told to put their luggage in the back and to take a seat anywhere they wished. As the van started to move into the incoming traffic, the man introduced himself.

"My name is Dan. I work for the people you are coming out to work for, and as long as you are here, I will be your source of answers for any questions you might have."

"Pleasure to meet you, sir. My name is Kyle, and these are my friends, Kushnov and Alex."

They rode on in silence, noticing the still beauty of Alaska and the vast wilderness that seemed to welcome those who were prepared. Kushnov thought that it was probably the closest place to Russia. He reasoned that he must be right since it was purchased from Russia by the Americans, so surely it still had its Russian touch.

As they neared a tunnel, it became apparent that the place they were going was not going to be a very public space. The van was swallowed by the tunnel that led underground, and then the van came to a halt.

“This,” said Dan, “Is where we will board the electric train. If you follow the yellow arrows, then you won't get lost. Anyway, it's only a short walk to the train station.”

Kushnov, Kyle, and Alex eagerly followed the breadcrumb-like trail of arrows till they came to a light source: a security point.

“Welcome to the station, fellas!” said a man who probably didn't see new people that often. “If I could have your name and ID, that would be great. Unless you would like to go home...” he said, in a joking manner. As Kushnov gave him his ID, the man asked,

“Name, please?”

“Kushnov Serca, sir.”

“Great, have a nice day.”

As the man went through each person's ID and name, they were made to go into a line and wait until everyone was clear to go past the door. Kushnov could hear fans turning on as the air ducts pumped in new air for them to breathe. As the door opened, the security man said with a normal smile,

“You're free to move on.”

They walked down the hallway past the guards and then, without realizing, found themselves in a large train station with only a handful of people already waiting to board the absent train. Then, without a sound or an alarm, the train rode up silently to the boarding pad.

“All are free to board,” said a robotic female voice.

As everyone found their seats in the train, the doors closed, and it began to move with purpose. None of the tired friends knew what to expect.

Chapter 2

The train to a new world.

Kushnov got comfortable on the train as it sped through the large system of tracks and the maze of tunnel; he could only see outside the windows of the train every now and then, but as they sped along to their destination, it was made clear that they would soon see the light of day again, for Kushnov and his friends could see a bright light at the end of what they thought was the tunnel, and as expected they were blinded by the moon's brightness and beauty. It was what Kushnov dreamed of: being in the wilderness. As soon as the light hit the eyes of the three friends, they understood where they were: deep in the depths of Alaska, slowly going to the border of Canada. Though they were interested in the new sights that they saw, their eyes begged for sleep.

"Just another thing we need to gain control over," said Alex. "We need to learn how not to become slaves to our senses, one of which is our eyes."

"That's not a bad idea," said Kushnov, "but for now, I'm going to let them triumph victorious."

As they slept, the train drove with purpose to its destination, and before they could wake up, they were at the point of interest. As Dan woke everyone from their slumber, he bid everyone to get off. "Unless you wish to go back to your mommies," he said.

"How did you know that?" interrupted Kyle, sarcastically and seriously at the same time. They departed the train and were searched by stern men.

"This is the place where they actually care about security," said Dan.

"It's a shame they couldn't have done the bigger search earlier," thought Kushnov. He reasoned that if they had done a good job at searching them, then they wouldn't have to waste time doing it all over again. Slowly but surely, every man and his belongings were searched, and before long, they were led into an odd-looking car. Once again, they slowly but surely went through the systems of roads and caves, and before they went to the 'Main Base', as it was called, dropped their stuff off at the room they were staying in.

"Shame we have to sleep with this creep," said Kyle, poking fun at Dan who already was enjoying their company.

"I don't believe in taking showers." said Dan, who was going along with the joke. "Some people have died in this room; if only they didn't try to make me take one." He shook his head as if to make it seem more serious.

"Well, better than being in the same room as a serial killer, I guess." Kushnov added.

"Sorry that I had you fooled." Dan responded. As they left their new home, they were led to the main mess hall. "This is where you get to eat, if you're good enough," Dan said, "But you boys should be OK."

As they met the people who would be training them, one man who stood out from among the others came to the center of the room; Kushnov could tell that these people obviously knew who he was, and they made a circle around him. "Welcome, gentlemen, to the base, or should I say camp, Camp Vostok, to be exact." He let the words sink in. "I'm glad you could make it, and I hope you fellas are comfortable." He continued with a hospitable smile on his words. "I would like to introduce myself. My name is Jack, and I'm the leader of this camp. I intend to make sure that everyone here knows who you are, so please, introduce yourself."

Being the leader of the group, Kushnov was pushed forward gently by his friends.

"My name is Kushnov, and these are my good friends, Kyle and Alex."

"Nice to meet you." the people said in reply.

"Well, hopefully you can find your way," said Jack, "And if you need any help with directions or where to go, ask me or Dan or anybody who looks like someone slightly smarter than an idiot. You're all free to leave and go wherever you wish."

As they all left, the three friends thought that it would be best to eat and then look around and make themselves at home. They asked Dan if it would be OK, and he said,

"Sure, just don't get lost, and don't go in any doors that don't have a name on them."

So the three friends went on their expedition. Soon, they found out just how large Camp Vostok was.

"Wish we could get a ride to go around here, these walkways are so long." said Alex.

"Sure, why don't we see where to find a golf cart or something?" responded Kyle.

"Let's ask Dan," suggested Kushnov. "We have only been walking for 30 minutes, so he is probably not far, if he isn't busy with anything." So they canceled their expedition so they could look for Dan, but instead of finding him, they ran into Jack.

"You fellas need anything?" he asked.

“We were wondering if we could get a UTV or something to go around the place?” asked Kyle.

“Sure, just go down to the nearest phone and call the main office, tell them that you're in Sector Five, and ask them to send you a golf cart. Good luck!” he added.

“Thanks!” The three friends said in unison.

“Cool place.” said Alex.

“Very cool place indeed.” agreed Kushnov with a nod.

Chapter 3

Camp Vostok.

Camp Vostok had been quite a new experience for the three friends.

"Gee, I wonder why we were even allowed to come here," said Alex. "Camp Vostok is obviously the coolest place I've been to since going to the bunkers in Washington." said Kushnov.

"Sorry to ruin the fun, but perhaps we should go back to our rooms now; this place is huge and I'm not planning on getting lost on our first day." said Kyle.

"We might as well." agreed Kushnov. So as they drove back to their barracks, they quietly thought about what they had gotten into. Before long, they were back in the entrance of their barracks.

"Where should we leave the golf cart?" asked Kyle.

"We can just leave it outside the door for now." Alex said. They went inside, but were surprised to find no one in the room.

"Where did everyone go?" asked Alex. Then, without warning, Dan and his four men pounced upon Alex, Kyle, and Kushnov, and the three friends were well aware of their capture.

"You're going to need to work on your reaction time and your sense of your surroundings." chided Dan as he released Kushnov.

"Next time we will be ready," responded Kyle. "But it won't be that easy." As Dan quizzed them on how to respond to a hand-to-hand combat situation, they answered with short but clear answers. "If you're so smart, then why didn't you think about being attacked?" asked Dan.

"I guess we felt secure and comfortable here, so we didn't think we needed to worry about that." responded Kyle.

"You're never safe unless you're locked in a padded cell in space." said Dan. Then he added, "Remember this lesson, or you won't be living long in the Zone."

The three understood what this lesson was, and they didn't want to be shamed and not learn anything.

"What's the Zone?" asked Kushnov.

"Ah," said Dan, "I was wondering when you'd ask! The Zone, more specifically called 'Zone 3032', was found to be a hotspot for anomalies, and its exact location is kept private... but since you will need to know that part, I will tell you. Zone 3032 is located somewhere in Moscow, Russia," Dan continued, "And although we are not sure about where its heart is, we do know its main home is there. The main reason it's so special is because of how it has reacted to everything else around it. Before it went out of hand and became impossible for the Russians to control, it was smaller and easier to contain."

"So it's actually grown, then?" asked Kushnov.

"Not exactly. It's only let other anomalies grow around it; that area is what the Exclusion Zone is called because it's just a lot of smaller ones. It's odd since Zone 3032 itself doesn't grow, yet the Exclusion Zone does, if that makes sense."

"Sure it does," said Alex, "but how has it affected the size of the actual Exclusion Zone, then?"

"That's what is interesting, and in fact, that's why you're here," responded Dan. "We want to run some tests in the heart of Zone 3032, but we aren't able to do that publicly, and since the Russians won't even let us go over it without satellites, we need to get some men who know how to go into the Zone and do some scientific tests, and still stay alive. We need you guys to—well, you don't need to know that right now, but I promise that you will soon be told what your training is for if you plan on going on with the mission, after your training is complete."

This interested the friends greatly, and they began to ask more questions about the Zone.

"So, why should we care about the Exclusion Zone if it isn't on our soil?" asked Kyle.

"It's not a problem yet," Dan responded, "but we have been monitoring the land that it has taken, and it seems to be growing faster than the Russian Government can handle, so we plan on at least learning something about it before it starts to get really out of hand. So in short," Dan concluded, "We just need scientific data on Zone 3032 that can help us with protecting our citizens from it, since the Russians won't give us any data on it."

"Why, then, can we just walk into it?" asked Alex. "Wouldn't we stand out being the only people in the Zone?"

"Not exactly," responded Dan. "See, many people have found the whole Exclusion Zone to be a great place to make money, so they go into it all the time and survive in

it. The only problem is that there are many enemies, odd animals, orbs that kill you, and both soldiers and research teams that don't like other people in their business."

"So it wouldn't be odd for us to be in the Zone, then?"

"No, not at all, they will still try to kill you, but they won't bother too much, or, as much as they would if they saw US soldiers there." As they all talked and learned about the Zone, Dan told them to go to the library.

"There is a lot of information about the Exclusion Zone, and it's all open to you, so feel free to sink your minds into the well of information." With that, they parted ways and went to the library, where Kushnov found himself looking at the old maps of Moscow.

"Shame we don't have new and better maps that actually show what it's like in the Zone." he said.

"Maybe they have a Gift Shop there where they sell maps." joked Kyle.

"Map or not," Alex said, "It seems that all these books about the Exclusion Zone don't even talk about Zone 3032."

"Why should they?" Kushnov responded. "Dan said it is classified, and if that's so, then this library probably wouldn't have anything on it."

"Why don't we try to learn about some of the stuff they use to research in the Zone?" suggested Kyle.

"Sure." Alex agreed.

"I'm going to stay here and ask around about the maps." Kushnov said. "Good luck, though." As Kushnov asked around about whether there were any new maps of Moscow, he found that most people didn't know.

"Sorry, sir," one man replied, "But I don't think you will be able to find anything unless you have access to the classified area."

"Where would I find that area?"

"Just go to the head librarian, and she will tell you. If not, then go and find Jack; maybe he could let you go into his private library. Anyways," the man added with a smile, "Good luck!"

With that, he left.

"Drats." Thought Kushnov. "Now I'm on a wild goose chase, and I'm not even sure where to start." Kushnov decided to start by going to the head librarian.

"You want to go to the classified area?" she responded, "Sorry, but I don't know where that is; you should just ask Dan or Jack; they've been here longer than me." So Kushnov thanked the lady and went to find Jack, thinking, "Surely he knows something about where to find it."

Chapter 4

The Exclusion Zone.

Without much difficulty, Kushnov found Jack's office. "Hey there, my man, how can I help you?" Jack asked.

"I'm wondering if you could help me with a few hard questions."

"Sure, what would they be?"

"Well, I was told about the Exclusion Zone and Zone 3032 by Dan,"

"Poor man can't keep secrets." Jack interjected while shaking his head.

"Do you know where I could find modern maps of Moscow and the whole zone in general?"

"Sure, if you really want to see them, just go into the library and find the maps computer. You can just search for 'Moscow' in the maps section. We don't have any paper copies, sadly, but that should work just as well."

"Thanks," said Kushnov, and then added, "And could you tell me what we know about Zone 3032—and the whole Zone in general?"

"Sure," said Jack. "Get a chair and sit down, my man." Kushnov sat down and waited.

"Do you want a drink or anything before I start?" Jack asked.

"I'm good."

"Ok, then. It all started when the Russians started a research project that would supposedly help them find free energy from Earth. As you might know, they didn't get that, but they did find that random balls of energy would appear out of nowhere in the heart of Moscow. They had three bases where they tried to find the free energy that they were looking for, but only the one in Moscow provided anything since the others were underfunded. So they closed the others and put all the money for the project into the one in Moscow, but not long after that, they just stopped. It's like they found something that they didn't want to find, and they just disappeared. So they closed the project and burned the papers on everything they researched.

"Lucky for us, they had already made the papers public before this happened, so we know what the last thing that they were testing was. They wanted to see if they could take energy from special rocks that contained lots of electrons. They found that after extracting pure electrons, they could split the electrons into even half electrons. Before long, they realized that the electrons were able to be grouped into balls that gave visible light. The only issue was that this was small-scale, and they were not stable because, at the heart of it, the electrons were only able to stay together because they were simply not willing to combine with other things.

"So that's all we know of what they were doing, and based on some insider knowledge, it seemed that they stopped a test right in the middle of it. Then we found out that they blocked off all of that area within a mile and put security around the whole perimeter. Before long, though, people were getting in via the sewer, and they found that the Russians were still researching inside the facility. That was 40 years ago, and after about three years of it being closed, the whole darn facility exploded--or they say the building next to it did--destroying the research facility, but we know it's all a phony.

"After that, our satellites noticed large groups of people being moved away, and the whole city being deserted, minus those who were still alive and a part of the government research project. Sadly, that was when the US had to make a choice: either maintain friendly relations with Russia, or end our friendship and spy on the zone. We, as you know, chose the first option since we didn't think it was something that would affect us, but now we are noticing how big of a problem it is, and now we are working on a mission that will place you fellas into the core of Russia, and hopefully we will be able to at least learn something about the Exclusion Zone, or even better Zone 3032."

"Interesting, that gives us a lot of questions, then. Makes sense now why you need a research team to check that out. Anywho, thanks, that really does help." Kushnov said, getting up. "One last question, why is it called Zone 3032?"

"We don't really know," said Jack with a shrug. "The people who live in the Zone—against the law—call it that, and the government calls it that, so we just chose to follow suit."

"Well," Kushnov said, getting up. "I don't want to keep you from your work, but thank you very much for that bit of information!"

"No problem, Kushnov, and if you have any other questions, please feel free to come and ask me whenever." So, with his questions answered and his new knowledge of the Exclusion Zone, Kushnov went back to look at the maps. "This is going to get interesting," he said to himself. "Maybe I will write a scientific paper on the Zone and

all we know so that we won't forget." And with that, Kushnov made his way to the library to study.

Chapter 5

Moscow and the world around it.

As Kushnov was talking to Jack, Kyle, and Alex were looking into how the scientists researched in the Exclusion Zone. Before long, the two friends were finding themselves quite at home with all of the data collection tools. Well, almost all of them.

"It's that same darn tool that we can't figure out anything about, the AIED machine!" exclaimed Kyle.

"Why don't we do a mass word search on the library computer, then?" suggested Alex.

"Sure, why not." responded Kyle, still evidently irritated. They signed in to the computer and searched 'AIED machine', but were surprised to find only one book about it. "So, according to this book, AIED stands for Advanced Imaging Electron Detector." Kyle said.

"What is it used for?" asked Alex.

"The book says it's used for extracting data on the composition from the samples of anything that you want to test, it measures the amount of protons, neutrons, and most of all, electrons, while still being portable." said Kyle, now getting interested.

"So, how do they use it in the Zone?"

"It doesn't say." While the three friends continued reading and studying in the library, Kushnov found himself looking at a book on the Exclusion Zone and the men who lived there.

"It seems," Kushnov told Kyle, "That the people are in groups of factions and they all seem to want the Zone to be left alone. One faction is the government one, called Sparta, while the scientific research one is called Scorpion. The bandit factions are not named, though, probably because most of these people who write about the Zone have never even been to it."

"That's interesting," Kyle said, "It's very clear that we've learned something about the Exclusion Zone, but it's apparent we have learned nothing about the creatures or the natural living things that live there."

"We should ask the librarian about that."

Kyle and Kushnov went down to the library to talk to the librarian, and to their surprise, she told them to go down to the basement.

"You might need to sign in, but they should let you go." she said. "And if they don't, just tell me and I can help you."

Kyle and Kushnov went to get Alex, and then proceeded down to the basement; without any problems found themselves in a treasure trove of information on The Exclusion Zone.

"It's odd that the creatures that are in this guy's notes are all mutated versions of the real version." said Kyle. "A normal Deer in this case is called a Devil's Donkey, and it hunts its prey with its antlers; or a more common one, a Ripper, a mutated dog that loses all its senses except for sound, and gains the ability to sense fear."

"I'm surprised that the animal is mutated and not killed." responded Alex. "Let's just hope there isn't a mutated human."

"It doesn't say," said Kushnov. "And considering that our classic dog and deer are no longer friendly when mutated, I wouldn't be surprised if the humans were not much better."

So they researched more and more about the zone and found that scientific data and information were hard to come by, even when they were in the part of the library that was classified. As they slowly went through all the books, they found to their surprise that many people had actually been to the Exclusion Zone, but not many had lived longer than 24 hours. "So are we going to even accept the job?" asked Alex, "I mean we still haven't been hired for going to the zone, we are just here for training.", "I'm not sure, the zone seems to be very dangerous, so I'm not going to make my decision before my training is done. After we are done with training, I will decide." replied Kyle. "What about you Kushnov?", "I've already set my mind on learning more about the zone, and I don't want to learn from books, I want to have experience. So yes, I've made my mind to go on if you are all still willing to when our training is done." So the three friends thought it would be best to talk to Jack about the training. "Good question." Jack said, "Your training will start in about 2 days, but we knew beforehand that you were a smart gang and so we planned on you just reading for a day about your new enemy. If you wish to start your training earlier, then that's ok with me.", "I think that would be the best for us." said Kushnov. "Alrighty then, all three of you will be at the entrance of your room by 23:30 this evening, and you will start your defense training class at exactly 24:00 this evening. See you then." So they left and went to their room to prepare. "You think we should do anything before we go?" asked Alex. "Nah, we're good. It's not like we can be prepared for anything anyway, not having any belongings." replied Kyle. So they left and stood outside their door early and waited until their teachers arrived.

Little did they know the next 24 hours would be their hardest and most rigorous 24 hours of their lives.

Chapter 6

The 24-hour campout.

"Hello there, my name is Tyler, and I'm going to get you ready to start your short-notice camping trip. Please follow me, your gear is in those bags, and if you could put on the clothes on top of them, that would save us some time. So let me explain what is happening, you boys will be given a 1-hour-long course on how to parachute into the wilderness of Alaska with all that gear, and then you will try to survive as we attack you. Simple, and while it all happens, we will also give you three each an earpiece so that you can hear us in the main control room, don't think that failing doesn't bring pain, it could mean a few days in the hospital here." The three, without question, put on their clothes and earpieces and, before long, were ready to start their parachute training. "My name doesn't matter, what matters is that I'm the dude who will teach you how to jump from a cargo plane into the woods and hopefully not break anything. Any questions before I begin?" The three shook their heads. "Ok then, please notice that your bags include a built-in parachute. If you pull those blue handles attached to the cords, then the parachute will open. Normally, if we were to be doing low altitude drops, then we would just have you pull the cord right when you jump, you will not be doing that, you will wait exactly 5 seconds, THEN you will pull the cord. Is that clear?" "Yes, sir." the three friends said in unison. "Alright, let me see each of you try to pull it. Good, you're getting it, now just remember to pull that string when you drop in, it will leave the parachute on the ground since we can't use them again. They were made to disintegrate in water so that the Russians, if they come and try to find them, won't be able to, so it won't be littering." Tyler told them.

So they spent exactly 1 hour practicing how to jump, and when it was done, the three were made to run to the underground tarmac. "When you guys see the doors open and the green light turns on, then you are free to jump, just make sure to crack your glow sticks beforehand so you can see." Jack told them with the earpiece. "And good luck." he told them.

So the three boarded the cargo plane, and after getting to drop altitude and making sure they were on target, the doors opened and the green light turned on. The 24-hour timer started. "Great, here goes nothing." Kushnov said. As he jumped, he could almost feel time slow; the fear of jumping was overcome by the time he counted to five, and

before he knew it, he and his friends were slowly descending into the wilderness. As they touched the ground, the old problem of actually jumping and making the landing disappeared, and a new one came. "So what now?" asked Alex, knowing that they didn't really have a plan. But before Kushnov or Kyle could respond, their earpieces told them what to do. "Shame you forgot to plan. When and if you're in the Exclusion Zone, you won't be able to ask us what you're going to do, but then again, you have plenty of time to learn. For now, don't get caught, we have fake patrols that are looking for you, and if they find you, the game's over. We didn't spend the time training you guys to get out here for nothing, so just don't get caught." The earpiece went silent. "Well, let's figure out where the patrols are, then let's get away from them." said Kyle. "Good idea." Kushnov responded. So as they walked, going from tree to tree in order to maintain their stealth, "I see a light." Whispered Kushnov. "Let's get a little closer then, just beyond reach of the light." Alex said. So as they stealthily ran to the light, they could see the silhouette of the men patrolling. "Only five of them, we should probably just retreat and go back into the thicker part of the woods." Kyle whispered, barely audible to his friends. But when all seemed to be going well, the light moved to their side of the woods. "Enemy spotted over there!" a man yelled, and after that, everyone went into panic mode. Running for their lives (or so it felt), the three ran like mad. "What should we do? They are hot on our heels, and we don't really have a plan; they have numbers, and we still have 22 hours of running around." said Kushnov. "Let's split up and just run towards the moon, then we should just stop and hide, see if they pass us. How does that sound?" said Alex. "Ok, see you all in a little," responded Kyle. As they split, the patrolmen began to light the sky with flares. This is a lot just for some training, hopefully it's worth it, Kushnov thought. Before long, Kushnov was tired and stopped running and hid in a large bush, he could hear the rustling of leaves and bushes as a few men passed him. Great, he thought, now what? Just run backward? So he made a run for the area where the light was originally, and after running for 30 minutes, stopped and put his gear down. He could still see the lights moving in the forest even though they had been running around for hours already. How much longer? Had it been 3 no 4 hours already of pure running? As the sunlight started to hit the tops of the mountains, he could make out a faint green glow. "It's the glow stick!" He told himself, "I need to go there now." So he ran and ran until he found it. There was the other two friends eating some food. "Wish to join for a little tea?" Alex said, jokingly. "Yes, please, but why did you get it?" Kushnov replied, "From the bags we were loaded with, Kyle found me and we just sat here, put the glow stick on the tree. You were almost late for breakfast." So as they ate they decided to pack everything up and check the time. "We've been out here for 20 hours, I'm surprised we're still stuck here." Kyle exclaimed. Just then, their earpieces came alive again. "Go to the extraction site, the river bed that is on your maps in your bags. Be there in 1 hour." it told them. "Heck! We'd better start

running or we will be late!" Kushnov said. So they packed up camp and made a sprint for the river bed. "Throw a smoke grenade on the bed and wait, they are located in your bag also." the earpiece told them. So they dropped a smoke grenade and waited. Just moments before they could see the helicopter coming to get them, they could hear the loud crashing of trees and the large band of men coming to check what the smoke was. "They saw the smoke." Kyle said, downcast. "Let's just hope the chopper gets here before they do." Kushnov responded. It all happened in a flash, and before they knew it, the helicopter was right above them, and they could also see the men running at them. They got out just in the nick of time, and they had a few close calls. "I'm tired, I hope the rest of the learning is just books and writing." said Alex. Before they knew it, they were back in the bunker getting told what they did wrong. "You're not the worst people we've tried to find, but some of the risks were maybe a little overkill. Next time, just hunker down, at least you didn't get caught." Dan told them, "You're free to go to bed or read, we will be back, and I plan on you guys taking some smaller classes that don't require much running, just mostly thinking." So they went to bed and passed out; it had been the most tiring 24 hours of their lives.

Chapter 7

Training for Real Men.

The next day after the whole 24-hour campout was the most refreshing; Kushnov and his friends spent most of their time reading and learning about defense tactics. "If you wish to live in the Exclusion Zone, then you're going to have to get good at defending yourself," The teacher told them. "Almost all the enemies are going to have guns like you, so you might want to learn some close combat skills with subcompact weapons."

"So what's going to be the most common weapon in the zone?" asked Kushnov.

"Probably the classic AK-47, but you might see a few shotguns, or if you run into Sparta soldiers, then AK-74's or 12's. And once in a blue moon, an MP5."

"So what do we get?" Kyle asked.

"What?" The teacher asked.

"What guns do we get?"

"Oh, yeah, you're going to be getting the AK-12, which is a Russian weapon since your ammo will be limited."

"Thanks, that's cool," said Alex. "But will we get to test them out?"

"Sure, let's go to the range." So the three took the small trek to the range and to their surprise were given quite stock weapons. "If you have lots of gear," said the teacher, "You will look like you are funded. We won't object to you buying anything for it, but only when you're in the zone. Plus, the stores in the zone will have plenty of things for your weapon if you don't die before getting there." As they tested their gear and got used to it, they found that the weapons were quite heavy. "You don't think we're going to take all our gear for survival, plus all your scientific junk, do you?" asked Kyle. "We don't expect you to be weak. Most of the testing gear will be in safe stashes that are littered around the zone." The man explained. "But it's still going to be a lot of walking; you're going to start in the wilderness about 277 miles from Moscow in the city of Klinsky, but don't worry, they have large transport trucks so it shouldn't be too big of a problem, it's just how much you're willing to pay." They continued to shoot for a little while longer, then went to the library to learn about the terrain of

the area. So, from that day on for a week, they always got up, went to class, trained using their guns for one hour, and then studied in the classified area of the library. "Well, we're almost done with your training, but you still have some more Russian to learn. We need you to be somewhat fluent in it so nobody assumes you're American." Dan said. "Assuming you have been reading and learning Russian this whole time, of course." The three nodded. "Well then, I'm going to have to get you some nice uniforms that won't stand out. But until I get those, you're probably best just spending the time learning about the way you're going to be transported there. Tyler will explain the whole process."

"Thanks, Dan." Alex said. As soon as Dan had left, a man named Tyler came into the room to brief them on how they would get into the zone.

"So, we are going to start by getting you three, a quick reaction force, and a few transport vehicles into a C-17, then we will have you fly to Kyiv, Ukraine. You will board a stealth Blackhawk helicopter and get dropped into the abandoned city of Udav. The rest you've been told of already. I plan on getting a written report of the plans and printing them for you guys, just so you don't forget."

So, the three friends finished all their training, all except the scientific kind. "Your last month of training," a man in a lab coat told them, "Will be purely put into learning about the machines and the methods that you will use during your tests and observations when you're in the zone. You're going to be given a large test that will last the whole week after you're done studying. Your books are in your rooms already, and if you need anything else, just call the main office; they will forward your message to us. Good luck." After this, Alex, Kyle, and Kushnov continued to spend all their time studying and learning about what tests they would be doing in Zone 3032, if they ever got there.

"This has to be the most complicated book of my life," Kushnov said. "I think our test will just be one big test for us all to work on. So we could just each study one large section and compile our brains for the final test." "Sure, that sounds better to learn something in depth instead of studying for no reason." Alex responded. "It's all just too much information for one person to handle." "Ok, Alex, you study the books about the methods we will use to test things in the zone. Kyle, study the machines and other equipment we are using for the tests, and I will study the environment and all the anomalies that they want us to know about." "Sounds like a plan." Kyle replied. Thus, they spent all their weeks studying all that they were told to and at the end of the 3 weeks, they were given their final test. "You're going to have to complete this in a special room, you're still going to get your food, but we don't want you to use the computers or any books. Just your brains." The lab coat man told them. "If you get above an 80%, then you're good, but any lower and you're going to have to

try again." "Thanks, we will try our best." Kyle replied. "Don't try, DO your best. See you in a week." The trio took the papers and entered the test room. "Quite the test, let's make sure we all get our subjects right, hand me the papers." Alex said. "Ok, here you go, Kyle, here you go, Kushnov. Let us begin." They spent most of their time working, but they sometimes ate and slept. "I'm going to take a break." Kushnov told his friends. "I'm just tired." "Ok." Alex responded. Kushnov woke up to the sound of panic. "We've only got 24 hours and we still have the hard questions." Kyle exclaimed. "Well, let's get to work, you to Kushnov." Alex responded. As soon as Kushnov had got up, he was put to flight with the amount of work that was still undone. Let's see, he thought. I've only got 24 hours to answer these questions, better start with the hardest one. "Do any of you know what the AIED is and what it stands for?" Kyle asked. "Let me think about that." Kushnov responded. After a long pause, Kushnov came up with an answer. "It stands for Advanced Imaging Electron Detector. I remember when we did a word search on it because we were researching the zone." With that question answered, the rest of the questions that they had left were done in no time, and before long, they were done. "What's done is done, and now all we need to do is wait for our grades." So they left their rooms and went to the mess hall. "How did it go?" a random person asked. "We don't know yet, but hopefully we did a good job." Kyle responded. They hadn't eaten anything other than simple healthy foods in a week, and they were dying to eat a hearty soup. "I've never wanted soup so bad." Alex said. "It's like I'm crazy." "You probably are." responded Kushnov. Before long, and to their surprise, they were contacted. "Your grades are in, they asked you to be there in 5 minutes." A man in a uniform told them. So they rushed as fast as they could to Jack's office. "Welcome, men, your grades have come in, as you know, and the results are baffling," Jack told them. "You passed, and with good grades at that, your grades were in total a decent 90%. In layman's terms, you passed and are, if you want, able to start your mission. Congratulations." He added a smile to his speech. The three thanked Jack for the news and told them that they would have to think about it. "Whenever you're ready, or not ready, come back." So they left and went to their rooms. "It's quite the mission, but I'm up for it since it means the safety of America and the idea of being able to serve the US would be an honor." Alex said. "I'm ready to go, if you all feel like it, then I'm all in." said Kushnov. "Since you're all in and it seems to benefit everyone, then I'm in. Let's go tell Jack." Kyle told them. So they left for Jack's office, none of them knew what laid in store for them.

Chapter 8

Preparations.

The three friends, after passing the test, found themselves in a flurry of things to do. They needed to get their gear and make sure they had everything they would need for the mission. "I think that's it." Kushnov said as he grabbed his bag. "Here we go, three friends into unknown territory. Wish us luck, America." Alex said as he boarded the C-130 filled up with all their gear. The C-130 was a special stealth version; it had only been used in special missions that needed the plane to remain completely invisible to all, and it wore the large name NIDS on the tail and the side of the fuselage. It had been a work of art when it was brand new, and it still didn't show any signs of age. "Goodbye, Alaska. I'm not sure if I will make it back, but I'm sure it's for a good purpose." Kyle said, as he made a wave to all those who stood far off in the underground runway. The friends found themselves quite energized, filled with the energy that was passed from the others stress. This mission meant a lot, and if they were to succeed, it would mean the safety of all the citizens of America and others. So as they waited, they passed the time by playing games and telling each other riddles. "You peel me, and then you cook me, then you eat the outside and throw away the inside. What am I?" Alex asked his friends. "You're a food of some sort, right?" Kushnov asked. "Yes." "Avocado?" "No, you have to cook it." Before they could spend any more time on the riddle, the pilot gave an announcement. "All prepare for landing, please; we will touch down in 2 minutes. After that move all the supplies that we need to the helicopter and get out of here." "Well, you heard him." Dan said. As the plane landed, they could hear the tires hit the ground and whine as the tarmac and the rubber met. The plane shook as the brakes came on, making the plane halt. "Ok, the rear cargo door is coming down, and after that you all are free to get to moving that gear off this thing." The pilot said over the intercom. As soon as the plane stopped and the rear door opened, there was a flurry of activity; people came to and fro as they moved gear to the Black Hawk helicopter. As they got the last of the stuff that they needed, the friends were handed some papers. "These papers are everything we expect you to do on your mission; it's got all the data you might need in finding the caches and other things on top of that. Good luck." Dan told them after saluting. So the crew wished them luck and had them board the stealth Blackhawk helicopter. "Are you ready?" The pilot asked. "Yes sir, take us to Klinsky." Kushnov responded. As the majestic helicopter lifted off, they could see the city full of lights. "Beautiful, the scenery should be stunning in Klinsky, since there are no lights." Kyle

said. So they drifted away, leaving the civilization that they knew and going to a new land of unforeseen possibilities. As soon as they crossed the Russian border, they could no longer see any lights. "Feel free to turn your night vision on." The operator told them. "Seeing all the abandoned buildings will definitely help you understand the scale of it all." As Kushnov turned his night vision on, he could see the darkness run away as the world turned green; his eyes adjusted, and he could see the silhouette of the abandoned buildings of the city. "Good luck, men." The operator said. The three moved in silence. Their positions, Kyle and Alex on the left side and Kushnov on the right. When the pilot gave them the thumbs up, they opened the doors and dropped the rope. As the rope dropped to the earth, they could see it hit the ground with a thud. Kushnov looked at the men in the helicopter, gave them a nod, grabbed the rope, and slowly descended. As they descended to the ground, they could see the unlit world around them slowly cut the small amount of light away that the moon and the stars provided. As Kushnov got to the ground, he and his friends cleared the area. The helicopter dropped the rope and flew in a circle, finally turning away. "Heck, no turning back now. We've got to get shelter and hide. I wouldn't be surprised if there aren't any people around here." Kyle said. "And I'm willing to bet they don't want to see any visitors either." So they quickly got up and left for the heart of the city. As they slowly made sure that nobody was there, they entered a big apartment-like building. Climbing to the top, they made camp. It was cold, but as they turned off their night vision, they could see the stars. "Well, let's eat and go to bed." Alex suggested. So they cooked up some meat and warmed some beans. "This is great, being in the middle of an abandoned city eating some bland food on the top of a building." Kyle said. "Rental with a great view of the roof," Kushnov added. As they set up their sleeping bags and took off their gear, they laid their guns right next to them. "These have got to be the nicest guns I've ever owned." Kushnov said. "More expensive than your car." Alex jokingly said. "If I had one." So they slept in the deserted land of Russia. Shame Kushnov thought to lose such a nice land to the curiosity of scientists. They had a large day ahead and a whole journey that would test them beyond the limits that they knew. They knew that they would have to meet people that lived these odd lives. Making money off of the random tasks that were given to them. Living always in fear and never knowing what was in store for them. But didn't all men live their lives like that? Kushnov thought. Some just live under an illusion, while others live in reality. Kushnov thought over this as he went to bed.

Chapter 9

A warm welcome from a cold land.

Kushnov woke up to the sun. It felt warm on Kushnov's skin, and he could breathe in the freedom that the land provided. Before long, Kushnov got cold, though, as the clouds blocked the sun. Might as well start making breakfast, Kushnov thought to himself. As Kushnov unpacked all the cooking things

Alex woke up. "Good morning." Alex said. "Making breakfast?" "Yeah, I was starving, and it was cold." Soon, Kyle woke up, and the whole group ate some canned foods. "So we need to get to meet some locals without getting killed; how does that sound?" The three agreed to pack up and start looking.

for anybody who might help them get to Moscow. So they packed up and started to head down the stairs to the main doors. "Let's hope we find them first." Kushnov said. "I'm not sure how friendly the locals are." "Agreed." Alex responded. As they slowly walked through the streets, they stuck to the sides.

of the road so that if anybody might try to kill them, they wouldn't be in the open. "If I were a crazy person living in an abandoned Exclusion Zone in Russia, where would I be?" Alex said out loud. Before either of the friends could respond, they all saw in the distance a man walking down the street.

"What should we do? Go up and say hi?" Kyle asked. "Let's slowly walk to him and just act normal." Alex suggested. As they walked slowly to the man, he looked and saw them; to their surprise, the man waved and slowly began to walk their way. "Who is there?" The man asked. "Just some friends."

Alex responded. "What about you?" "I'm just a guide for anybody who needs some help." As Kushnov looked at the man who seemed to be in his 40s, he wondered why he was so nice. "Where are you from?" The man asked. "For now, that doesn't matter; not to be rude, but we're new here, so we don't

really want people knowing who we are or why we're here, but I would be glad to tell you where we are going." Kyle responded. "It's ok, I was just wondering." As the man got closer, they could better see his face; he looked Russian, and he had a Dragunov with a scope and a nice bag. "If you guys want

to come to the local bar, then we could talk there; most of the people mind their own business, and they aren't too nosy. There have been a lot of new people over the last 5 years, so they don't care too much about the new people, as long as they aren't from the government or something." The man said, "

Are you? You seem to have some nice gear, and you definitely look like you just came here." "We could probably talk a little more at the bar or whatever the place you're talking about is." Kushnov responded, "Let's go then," the man told them. As they made the small trek to the bar, they found that the

Locals were somewhat normal. All of them held some sort of weapon, and they all seemed nice. The man opened the door and had them enter. "This is the bar; it's just a hotel, but after everyone left, we repurposed it to be a meeting place." As they sat down, the man introduced himself. "My name

"I'm Dimitri Tarkov. What are your guys' names?" "My name's Kushnov; these are my friends. Kyle and Alex." "Nice to meet you. Are you new here then?" "Yes, we just got here last night." "So you're with the government?" "We're from the US." Alex said. "We would tell you more, but for now we're in a public space."

"We are trying to get to Moscow." Kyle added. "You think you could help us?" "Moscow?" Dimitri said. "That's far away, and it's really dangerous there; the zone seems to get stronger there. Why would you even want to go there?" "Can't tell you much, but we need to do some research there." Kushnov said.

"Ok. Well, I will take you there and back, but only if you help me." "Sure, what do you want?" Kushnov asked. "I want to become an American citizen. I'm very busy in the zone, and I'm too poor to get out of here. When I was young, I wanted to live in the zone, but after a while, it got boring and sad. Most of my friends

died, and ever since then, I have wanted to live in America. Sadly, the Russian government keeps the borders tight, and even if I were to get past, I don't have any real money to get any tickets to a place. If I help you and your American government get to Moscow and back, will you take me to America?"

"Sure!" Alex responded. "I will make sure that you get to America." "Thank you so much. I don't regret moving to the zone, but it really sucks the life out of you, so I'm really excited to get to see America for the first time." As the four friends talked, they formulated a plan; they would find a shelter and work from there.

"Do they have trucks?" Kushnov asked. "Yes," Dimitri said. "But they are easy to track and find, so I think our best bet is to take the main railway to Moscow, so all we need to do is find an entrance and just slowly walk all the way there. It won't take longer than a few days, and it's safer since there are always friendly people.

In the railway, the only time it's dangerous is when you exit the railway in Moscow or when a few mutated creatures get in through the air ducts." So they left the bar and started for the closest railway entrance." Before the Russian government evacuated the people out of Moscow, the government was building a large railway that would connect Moscow to all the smaller cities near the border. Before the explosion in Moscow, the railway was completed, but it was short-lived. The railway was only used for a few years, and the Russians seem to have forgotten it. The power still works, and some of the air ducts also do. Most

of the dead NIDS teams actually lived in the railway before they got killed." "How did they die?" Kushnov asked. "The story goes they were researching in Moscow when they were attacked by the Mechs. Some of them died as they fled into the railway, but once the rest got in and closed the doors, the orbs came in.

The orbs in Zone 3032 are crazy; they hunt people. The other anomalies sometimes do, but these orbs are just different. Anyway, the orbs came in through the air ducts and killed them all, very sad." "That's crazy. Did it ever happen again?" Kyle asked. "No, in fact, nobody has seen any orbs around the area since."

"Well, let's hope that doesn't happen to us." Kushnov said. "Yup, definitely an easy way to end your visit in Russia; just go to Zone 3032." "Wait, so we can't go to Zone 3032?" "You would have to be insane to. Why do you ask?" "We're supposed to go there and do some tests." Alex responded. "Well, I for now won't go into

the zone with you; you're free to, but I'm not going to take my chances." They walked in silence as they saw in the distance a hole with some stairs that went into the ground. "That's our door to the underground world. The people who live there called themselves the Lurkers; in fact, everyone from here to Moscow calls themselves that."

As they entered, they cracked their glowsticks. "Here's a glow stick, just in case the power goes out. Everyone has one; we get green, but most people are blue." Dimitri said as he gave each a green glowstick. "Don't crack it until the power goes out; it would be a waste." "Thanks," Kyle said as he put the glowstick in his bag.

"Here we go; we probably won't see the sun for a few days, but it's ok, way safer than walking through the woods on the roads where the government keeps patrols all the time." As they walked through the rails, they could see the makeshift huts and houses with people sitting inside and enjoying themselves. To Kushnov's surprise

The people didn't look at them with questions; they were friendly. One man offered Kushnov a paper cup with some tea. "It's good; I just brewed it. You're all free to take a cup if you want; sorry, there is no sugar." "Thank you." Kushnov said as he took the cup. He set the cup down and took off his bag. "One moment, Dimitri,

I need to get something before we continue." As Kushnov shuffled through his bag, the man looked on in fascination; he probably hadn't seen a bag full of fresh supplies in years, and he was very curious about what was inside. "Thank you for the tea; I hope you can use this." Kushnov said as he handed the man a bag of sugar.

"Why, thank you." The man said. "Please, if you're going to give me this, then please take some more tea." The man said as he gave Kushnov a water bottle full of it and a few tea packets. "Thanks again." So they continued. "Why are they so friendly?" Kushnov asked. "They don't get visitors that often, and so they wish to treat

them well. Most of the people here aren't criminals, and they aren't freaks either; most people come here for freedom and adventure. The only rude people are the ones who live in Moscow; they're not friendly at all." Dimitri said. As they moved on, the houses became less common. "The people who live here live in

larger cities; they like to stick together. They do leave space in between for people like us, though; it's sort of like free property. Just underground." "Let's take a break; we can eat some dinner and make it to the other underground city by two. So they sat down and ate. As they ate, Dimitri told a story about the zone.

"Let's get moving, though." Dimitri said. "We don't want to be late." So they packed up everything; they got out and started for the next stop. Not long into the walk, the lights went out. "Just to be safe, let's use those glowsticks. They never turn the lights off at these times." Dimitri said as he concerningly looked at his watch.

"I know why. The next city is under attack. Let's go." As Dimitri started running, Kushnov could sense the urgency from Dimitri. He knew it was serious when the city was attacked. As they ran to the mini city underground, they could hear the gunshots echo down the railway. I didn't seem good.

Chapter 10

Victims of the Zone.

As the four ran, they could hear the explosions in the distance get closer. "Let's slow down. We probably can't help them, so if we want to live, we better just stay low." Dimitri said. "In fact, let's get into the air ducts; if the power is out, then the air ducts are out." As they crawled into the air ducts, Dimitri inspected his map. As they

Slowly walking down the air duct, they found themselves looking down out of the little openings; they could see soldiers slowly clearing the area and civilians being rounded up. "We better move if we plan on making it to Moscow." Dimitri said. As they weaved through the seemingly endless lines of air ducts, they were

According to Dimitri, it's really close to the exit. "We're going to exit via the intakes up in the woods." Dimitri said. "As long as we don't take too long, the patrols shouldn't see us." As the metal grate was unbolted, they could see the outside light through the little slits that let the air through. "Last one," Kyle said as he took the last bolt off.

"Great, once everyone is out, we will have to screw them back on." Dimitri said. "You three stand guard while I do that." So Dimitri gave the signal as Kyle pulled the last bolt free. The three slowly and methodically got out and stood guard as Dimitri bolted the bolts back on; they could all hear a slow rustling in the distance bushes.

As it caught all their attention, the thing cleared the bushes. As it stumbled around trying to find the source of the sound that Dimitri was making, it slowly smelled the air. "Shoot it, you idiots!" Dimitri shouted. At that moment Kushnov unloaded 5 rounds into the beast in rapid succession. As it fell to the ground, they could all hear

the commotion. "Let's get out of here now!" Alex said with a hint of concern as he started to slowly move away from the loud rustling in the woods. "Follow me," Dimitri said, keeping his cool. As they ran, the sun slowly sank behind the trees, and the rustling slowly got quieter, and before long, it completely stopped. "That was crazy."

Kyle said. "I hope we don't run into any more of those things, Rippers or whatever they're called." "Let's not get off track here." Kushnov said, bringing everyone together into a huddle. "Right now we need to get to Kirov." Dimitri said. "Then we will get to the city of Kaluga, and after that we will make our way to Tula. It should only take

a few days, and after we get to Tula, we can board a truck to Podolsk, and then we can make our way into the city on foot from there." "Great." Alex said. "Let's get to Kirov then." So they slowly and stealthily made their way to Kirov; right before they got to the border, it was pitch black. "Let's turn on our NVGs." Kushnov said as he

flipped the switch on his. "I don't have any." Dimitri said. "Here you go, just mount them on your helmet." Alex said as he dug out the extra pair of NVGs. "Thank you." As Kushnov's eyes adjusted to the bright terrain that the night vision goggles showed, he could see lights far in the distance. "What are those lights?" he asked.

"I don't know." Dimitri said in reply. "Probably just some Russian Spetsnaz soldiers with some infrared lights." Kyle responded. "Great, just great." Kushnov said, shaking his head. "Are we to know Dimitri?" "Well, we might as well go into the large hotel on the west side of the city; it's normally uninhabited." As they stealthily walked

Into the city they could see the IR lights come and go. "There it is," Dimitri said, pointing to a large building. "Let's just climb the ladder to one of the safety exits." Soon they were at the foot of the building. "Follow me," Dimitri said as he started to climb the ladder. As they all climbed, they could hear the metal creak. Before long

The ladder stopped and gave way to a platform. "We can enter here," Dimitri said as he opened the door. "We can turn off our night vision now." Kushnov said. Slowly but surely they went through the building, checking each room and the floor. "Let's stay in this one; it seems to have little to no mold, and I'm tired of walking," Alex said.

"Ok." Kyle said in reply. They set their gear there and made camp. "I will make some food." Kushnov said, taking out his cooktop. "What do you all feel like? We got chicken soup, chicken soup, and some more chicken soup with a side of water. And for dessert we have cheese sticks." "Yum," Dimitri said. "I think I will take some chicken.

soup, please." Before long the soup was boiling in the pot, and Kushnov was serving it in little metal bowls. "This is some good food; normally we have to eat beans or something like that." Dimitri said. As the friends talked, the sun started to rise. "Well, do you have any energy drinks or something like that?" Alex asked. "Nope."

Kushnov responded. "If we get to the Kaluga, we can go to the camp and get some energy drinks; they sell all the fancy stuff there." Dimitri said. "Let's go then." Kushnov said, getting up. After getting out of the building, the four started on their way to the next city. Getting on the deserted road, they looked on as they saw an endless

collection of abandoned cars and trucks. The road was cold and long, and although they didn't get attacked, they were tired and ready to get to Kaluga. "Only 30 more

miles." Dimitri said, sitting on a car to catch his breath. "We can take another break and continue in a second." "Great, because I'm tired and ready to pass out," Alex said.

So they all shared plans and gave ideas of how to get into Zone 3032 as they took a break. "We will probably need to get into the sewers." Dimitri said. "It's our best bet." "Then let's get going." Kushnov said. As they slowly walked to the city, Kushnov could now see why people didn't come that often; it was unforgiving, and the forests looked like they would swallow you up. "Just ten miles till we get there." Dimitri said as he inspected his map. "We should be there by dinner time." Kushnov was thankful that the city was close; he could feel his senses slowly fade as he got more and more sleepy.

Chapter 11

The City of Kaluga.

Once they got to the city, the three friends could tell that it was where most of the travelers stayed; it was a smaller city, much smaller than any of the others that they had seen. Although on the top the city seemed to be small, below hid the truth. Large cave systems and tunnels that went to and fro only popping up inside abandoned

buildings or at the few bunker entrances that were in the woods. The main entrance was the largest; it was about the size of a Ural Typhoon, a large Russian military truck. Inside the door was a large elevator that was almost as large as the door itself. "Are we going down there?" Alex asked. "Yes, but don't worry. The locals are nice.

And if you want to see the real city, then you're going to have to come." Dimitri responded. A guard who was standing at the large door inquired of Dimitri and his friends. "Do you have any weapons?" The man asked. "We do, and we might use them on you if you don't let us in." Dimitri responded. To the three friends surprise, the guard

greeted Dimitri and his guests. "Well, please come in then." The man said, bidding them follow into the large elevator. "We were about to close for the day, so your timing was quite timely, to say the least." The man said as he put his hand on a large control box. With that, the man jerked a large lever down, and the elevator descended.

into the darkness. "What brings you here?" "We are on a journey to Moscow, and we thought we might get a ride there from here." Dimitri told the man. "That's interesting; well, you've come to the right place. The train has been in the shop undergoing large modifications, but it should be ready within a few days from now. Until

Then though," the man said, as the elevator came to a halt. "Enjoy your stay at the Marauder Mansion." As they left the elevator, they could see a light at the end of the long tunnel. "Welcome visitors." A voice said in the loudspeaker. "If you are planning on staying in the hotel, then please go into the left tunnel. If you're here bringing supplies,

Please continue going into the right tunnel, thank you." "This is new." Dimitri said as they walked down the left tunnel. "They normally don't care about which tunnel you go down. They probably put the train in the right tunnel so they could work on it, though." "Hmm," Kyle said, not thinking about anything other than sleeping. "When

Will we get to the housing part of it?" Alex asked. "Soon." Dimitri responded. As they walked down the tunnel, they could hear the opening and closing of blast doors. Before long they were in a larger area with lots of people. "Over here." Dimitri said with a wave of a hand. "This is where we are staying; it's very nice for being underground."

As Dimitri took a room, Kushnov saw a man slowly walk towards them. "I will show you your rooms; you all are going to be getting room 441." As the three friends walked, they could slowly notice how the loudness of the main area died down. "Here's your room; enjoy your stay." And with that, the man left, leaving the four to their room. "Help me real quick, Kushnov." Dimitri said, slowly getting his grip on the door. "One flaw with these rooms is the larger the number, the less used they are; that means that the door will probably be harder to open." As Dimitri and Kushnov twisted the locks and pulled the door open, they could hear a fan inside. "Follow me," Dimitri said.

slowly walking in. Once they all had entered the door, Dimitri turned the lights on; a blinding brightness burned their eyes. "Hey! The lights work; that's nice." Dimitri said. "Well, we're here; each of you gets a cot." With that Dimitri sat on his bed, took his gear off, and slept. Kushnov did the same; his eyes begged for rest, and so he went and turned the lights off. Before long they were all fast asleep.

Chapter 12

The Cargo.

When Kushnov woke up, he could hear the buzz from the old lights. "I'm all in for going to the train, but I want to get some food first," Alex said. As Kushnov rubbed the sleep from his eyes, the whole room became clear. "What are your thoughts, Kushnov?" Dimitri asked. Kushnov, trying to focus on the question at hand and not on his

aching body, shrugged. "Not sure. I am hungry, though." "Well then, we can eat first, and after that grab the stuff we will need for the trip. Then we can go to the train." Dimitri said, slowly walking out the door. "Meet me in the hallway." So Kushnov and Kyle got ready as Alex and Dimitri went down the hall. "Do you know where the

equipment cases are for the tests?" Kushnov asked. "Yes, I've been keeping track, and I believe we're going to have to pick up the cargo in the building only a little bit away on the edge of the town," Kyle responded. "We will probably have to get those today if we want to be leaving that train with all our gear." "Sounds good. Let's do that.

after we eat breakfast," Kushnov said. As Kushnov and Kyle met up with Alex and Dimitri, the two shared their plan. "So basically we were thinking, why don't you two go and get all the stuff we need for the rest of the trip to Moscow, and Kushnov and I will go get a cache of equipment that we need for the tests." "Sure, but you're going to

Get some help; there's a dude I know that could help you." Dimitri said, drinking his coffee. "Go to the main entrance and ask around for a man named Sergei; he is a great help and probably will be able to help you get that equipment onto the train." "Alright then, see you later." Kyle said, starting to walk out of the dinner made out of

boxes and random trash left behind by the Russians. Before long Kushnov and Kyle were out asking around for a man named Sergei. "Haven't found him yet. Do you think he is even here?" Kyle asked, looking around. "Why wouldn't he be here?" Kushnov asked. "Let's go to the main entrance and look around there and ask the dude who

operates the elevator." "Sounds good." As Kushnov and Kyle began to walk up to the main entrance, they saw a man loading a crate of ammunition. "Excuse us, but do you know where we would find a man named Sergei?" Kyle asked. "Sure, he just went up to the top; you can probably catch him if you get there fast." The man said, pointing.

to the large stairs that led up to the top of the main bunker entrance. "Thanks." Kushnov said as he ran towards the stairs. After an exhausting run up the stairs, Kushnov and Kyle found Sergei. "Yes, I can help. Just one problem: the train has to be loaded with the last of the cargo in a few hours, and I don't know where your stuff is." Sergei

responded. "It's supposed to be in one of the main buildings, room 177 of a random hotel." Kyle said. "Well, since there are only two hotels, you fellas can go check the one over there, and I will check this one. Be quick!" Sergei said, pointing to the two large buildings that were only a few minutes away but were very large and mostly destroyed. With that, Kyle explained to Sergei and Kushnov what the cargo would look like. "It's going to be just one large box." "That helps, doesn't it?" Sergei said, adding a sarcastic tone to his sentence. With that, y'all parted ways and began to check diligently the hotels, looking for room 177. "I found it," Sergei said over the radio. "Now be quick and

Come over here since we don't have too much time to fool around." As Kushnov ran to the hotel and slowly went up to the second floor, he could see Sergei's flashlight down the hall. "Over here." Sergei said. "We're going to have to move this out to the front of the building; after that I will call a man over to get the UTV." As Kushnov and

Sergei carefully moved the large box down to the front; they spotted Kyle. "Come help us." Kushnov said to Kyle. Once they got to the bottom after traversing the decaying hotel, Sergei called someone on his radio. Only a few minutes later did someone come. "Let's load this on the back of the transport," Sergei said. The four now lifted up

the box and began to tie it down. "Now we just need to drop it off at the train's loading dock." Sergei said. Once they got to the elevator, the four boarded it. With a sudden jolt, the whole platform began to descend down. After a short trip down and out of the elevator, the four made it to the train docks. A man helped them move the box.

onto the train. Once Kushnov got off, did he notice how the train actually looked? It was a short train with only a few cars, but it was heavily armored with steel plates on all sides of it. A large set of lights was on every side of the train, and each train car had a machine gun mounted on top. "Why is the train so heavily protected?"

Kushnov asked. "It's the only working train in this whole rail system, and if we lose it, we lose the rail system. It helps us transport supplies to other groups, and it also maintains security. The government sometimes gets inside and tries to cut us off, but that can't stop our train." A man, who was obviously proud of the train, said.

"Well, thank you for helping us," Kyle said. "No problem," Sergei said. "Well, we have to get going, but see you all later," Kushnov said. With that, Kushnov and Kyle started on their way to their rooms. Once they got to their rooms, they met Dimitri and Alex.

"How did your outing go?" Dimitri asked.

"Good, we found Sergei, and we also were able to load the cargo onto the train." Kushnov replied. "How about you two?" "It went well; we got all the supplies we will need to get to Moscow and also to get out of Moscow. We also got some more ammo and some more glowsticks." Alex replied. As the four began to catch up on the plans

that they had, they began to pack up. "The train leaves tomorrow and will make it to Moscow in only about 2 days, so we probably should get ready to board in a few hours." Dimitri said. "Well, let's get started then." Alex responded. So the four energetically began to pack and get ready. As soon as they were all done, they made their way to

the main area and gave the key back to the main hotel keeper. "Good luck in Moscow." The man told them as they started to go to the train. Before long they were on the train in a smaller cabin-like room; after dropping their gear, they took their seats and looked out the small slits over the window. "Wish they didn't have these large plates

on the windows," Alex said. "Not like you're going to see much," Kushnov responded. Before long, a man came into the room. "As you know, the train ride is free, but we do ask for your help with security. Thus, we expect one of you to go to the top and just keep a lookout. Don't worry about what you're supposed to do; the man there will teach you."

"I will then," Alex said. "I personally don't want to be stuck in here for the whole ride." "Great, follow me then, and the rest of you are free to check the rest of the train out if you wish." With that, the man took Alex to his job, and Kushnov made his way to the front of the train. There were only a few people actually on the flatcar that went

before the train. Before the train could start, though, the lights for the rail system flashed on. For a moment, it blinded Kushnov, but after his eyes became used to the light, he could see far down the railway. "All passengers, please be prepared to start your journey." A man with a smoker's voice said over the crackling radio that went all

around the train. And with a large stutter and some black exhaust, the train began to move down the tracks towards Moscow.

Chapter 13

The Train to Moscow.

As the train went down the tracks through the never-ending tunnel, Kushnov got bored; he soon left and went back to the train car and talked with Dimitri and Kyle. As the three talked, Kushnov got to know Dimitri better. Years ago Dimitri came into the zone for a research project funded by the British government. He had fled Russia because of the growing Exclusion Zone and went to Britain. After he got to know friends, he was asked if he would help do some research in the zone; once he was finished with it, he came back to the zone so that he could live free. "It's much better not having to pay taxes or anything like that. It was a really good choice to stay in the zone." Dimitri said. So they talked for hours on end as the train went slowly down the track. "Well, I'm going to get some food and check the rest of the train out." Kushnov said. "Enjoy yourself." Responded Kyle. With that, Kushnov made his way to the train car where the food supplies were. "What can I get you?" A man asked. "Just some coffee, please." "We don't have any. Is there anything else I could get you, though?" "Do you have water?" "Of course!" As the man went down under the storage box to get the bottled water, both Kushnov and the man noticed a large and fast buzzing sound fly by. The man's eyes shot up in surprise and concern. As the man began to run to the next car, Kushnov took the time to process what had happened. Why did the man leave? What was that sound? But Kushnov paid no thought to the questions as a large flurry of gunfire began to take over the air. Kushnov finally understood; they were under attack. As Kushnov began to run to the train car that Dimitri and Kyle were in, he noticed men running on the side of the track. Once he made it to the train car, he found Kyle and Dimitri getting all their gear. "Get ready." Dimitri shouted. "We're going to have to defend the train, and once we get to Moscow, we're going to have to unload all our supplies as fast as possible." So as Kushnov put all his gear on and loaded his weapon, he noticed the train began to pick up speed. A man came into the railcar. "We need everyone who's getting off at Moscow to be ready in an hour; after you're ready, get to the front train car, and fast," the man shouted, then he ran on. Dimitri led the way down the long line of train cars, and once they got to the first train car, they met Alex. "Are you ready?" Kyle asked Alex. "Will I ever be! This zone is a never-ending climax." Alex responded. "You men getting off at Moscow?" The operator asked. "Yes," Kushnov said. "OK, follow me." They followed the man down into the train car with their equipment for the tests. "You're going to have to get this off while we're moving; we will try to slow

down, but we can't make a full stop." The man said. "So when we get to the loading dock, we will slow down and try to let you off. After that, make sure to get into the offices; you can't let the government see you, or you're dead. Understand?" "Yes, sir," Dimitri said. As the loading dock came into view, the train made a noticeable brake; as the train car slowed down and came to the dock, the man yelled. "NOW!" With that, Dimitri and Kushnov took the box with the testing equipment and jumped out with Kyle and Alex close behind. "GOOD LUCK!" the man yelled. The train sped up, and the four scurried into the office space with the large box. Kushnov could hear the train make its way away, and a little bit after the train had left, he could hear running men run past the loading dock. The four sat in silence as the running faded away. "That was too close for comfort," Alex said. "Yeah." Kyle agreed. Dimitri was stunned. "In all my time in the zone, that has never happened," Dimitri said as he took a large gulp of water. "Well, no time to lose; let's get this gear out of here. So the four slowly took all the gear up into the sunlight. Kushnov was amazed at how Moscow looked; he had seen photos of it before it was deserted, but now it looked like it was from a new dimension. The large array of tall buildings and hangers with hundreds of condos and houses that were in some places destroyed—it was truly a large city. "Well, let's take this gear to that house over there," Dimitri said, pointing to a larger house on a large piece of property. So they slowly took the large box to the house and slowly moved it in. It was a large house with pillars at the front door and a large chandelier in the main room that came after the door. It had stairs leading up and wet carpet floors with green plants growing in the ground. "All wasted because of fear," Dimitri said. "It's really a shame people lived in this house," Kushnov said, looking at the decaying photos on the wall of people. "It's truly surreal." Alex said. "I would never have guessed there was a place like this in all the world. So they dropped the box in what looked like the living room and surveyed the house. The kitchen, although decaying and wet with mold, was at one point a beautiful kitchen with life. Now the house was lifeless, stuck in time. "It's so weird; it's as if the owners just disappeared. There are still personal belongings in all the drawers and on the shelves. Once the three friends were done looking over the house, they came back to Dimitri. "Well, we're almost in Zone 3032; it's only a day's walk from here, but since we need to be stealthy, we're going to probably take more like 4 days to get there." Dimitri said as he unpacked an MRE. "Here you go." Alex said, throwing an MRE and a bottle of water to Kyle and Kushnov. So the four ate in silence, listening to the wind and the sounds of the wild. As the sun went down, the world slowly began to come to life. "Let's move to the top floor; Moscow gets really dangerous at night." Dimitri whispered. Slowly walking upstairs, Kushnov noticed eerie blue lights robotically moving through the streets. Once they got to the master bedroom that overlooked the whole property and some of the streets, Dimitri spoke. "Those are the orbs; they hunt at night along with the other mutated creatures and people who live here." Kushnov looked out and

saw an orb slowly go by the house, its glow lighting up the whole street. “Let’s go to bed,” Dimitri said. “We’re safe inside for now, and we have a long day in front of us.” So they all slept, all except for Kushnov, who looked out into Moscow, thinking.

Chapter 14

The Heart of Moscow.

When Kushnov awoke, he could hear the sounds of shrieking in the distance. Kushnov got up and slowly made his way to the window, careful not to step on either of his friends. When Kushnov looked out the window, he could see mutated creatures running into the city of Moscow; it was an eerie sight. "Scary, huh?" Dimitri said, getting up. "Little bit. What are they after?" Kushnov asked. "Probably after humans; sometimes people on accident walk into the zone and get seen. After they're seen, it's most likely they're dead in an hour, but as long as we don't get caught, we should be fine. It's Zone 3032 we should be concerned about. I've heard stories of orbs hunting people inside Zone 3032; those who live there say it's as if the zone has an intelligence." Kushnov looked out into the city. "Let's hope that doesn't happen." As Kushnov got ready, Kyle and Alex were getting the box downstairs. "Can you help us, Kushnov?" Kyle asked. "Sure." Kushnov said, walking over to help with the box. As the three took the box downstairs to the back door, Kushnov found Dimitri setting up a box with some explosives. "What are you doing?" Kushnov asked. "Making a distraction, I am thinking it would be best to get the zone to react to this and run towards it rather than us; it should help us not get caught." Dimitri said, pulling an antenna out of the box. "Well, let's get moving; we should be able to get to the storage house that we need to in only a few days, considering my new tactic works." Once Dimitri was done rigging the distraction, he started for the door. "Let's go." Dimitri said with a wave of his hand. "Don't say a word while we go; the zone is sensitive to sound waves and other forms of energy." So Kushnov and his friends followed Dimitri closely, making sure not to make too much noise. After some time walking behind houses and random structures, Dimitri stopped and inspected his map. He gave the motion to follow him inside the house right next to them. He spoke in a whisper. "Once I set the distraction off, I want you to take the box and run into that garage over on the other side of the street, open the large metal door in the ground, and take the box into it. I will be right behind. After you get in, wait for me. If I don't come back soon, go down the tunnel for a little; I will meet you at the other end. Understand?" Kushnov and his friends nodded. Dimitri then lifted up his hand into the air with the remote and clicked the button. After a few seconds a large bang filled the air. Screams and loud noises could be heard around the area, and as Kushnov and his friends took the box out of the doorway and to the garage, he could see Dimitri run. What was he doing? Kushnov thought, but there was no time to think about

that because they had already made it to the garage, and now they had to open the door in the garage. After some difficulty, Kyle was able to open it and get inside. Kushnov dragged the box over, and after they got the box into the tunnel, Kushnov looked one last time out of the garage. He saw a bright flare in the sky. That dude must be crazy. Kushnov thought, almost saying the words out loud. Alex pulled Kushnov into the tunnel, though, and closed the door. "Let's get moving, and fast." Kyle said. "But we need to wait." Kushnov said. "Dimitri said we had to." "We don't know where he is right now, and if you ask me, I think he wanted us to meet him at another entrance." Kyle said. "Let's go." So Kushnov ran in front of the group and shouldered his AK. So the friends slowly made their way down the tunnel, and after a while Kushnov noticed a door at the end. Once they got there, Kushnov tried to open the door. It was firmly stuck. "Hey Alex, help me open this." So Kushnov and Alex pried at the door. The door opened slowly, creaking. Kushnov poked his head through. After a second of Kushnov's eyes adjusting to the light, he was able to determine what it was. It was a large room with a big door on the opposite side and a lot of smaller doors on the other four walls. In the middle, Kushnov could see chairs and cots lined up facing a platform. A large flag was hanging in the air. In the very middle was a waterfall. Kushnov slowly walked in. After a second Alex and Kyle also came in, dragging the box into the room. After stopping for a second, Alex slowly walked into the middle of the large room. "What is this place?" Alex said, touching the water fountain. "Must be a meeting place of some sort." Kushnov said, looking at the stage and chairs. "It is," Dimitri said, turning his flashlight on. Kushnov and his friends looked in amazement at Dimitri. "How did you get in here?" Kyle asked. "There are a lot of entrances into this place." Dimitri responded, walking onto the stage. "Cool place, huh?" He said, sitting down. "What's the big door for?" Kushnov asked, pointing. "That's why we're here." Dimitri said. "That's how we will get into Zone 3032; in fact, that's the only way to get into it." Dimitri got up. "Let's set up camp." Dimitri said as he walked to a corner. After Dimitri got to the corner, he flipped a large switch, and the whole room filled with light. The water fountain started to run. As the water flowed down the sides of the fountain, Kushnov could see the dust slowly fade away as the water picked it up and dragged it to the bottom. Kushnov had too many questions. Kushnov began to unpack as he soaked in his surroundings. "This place was made after the accident, when the government closed this part of Moscow. The US and British governments needed a way to study the zone without getting caught, so they hired Russians to make this place. It was originally a sewer, but after a little work, it was made into a meeting place for lead researchers and insurgents. As you know, the Russian government never found out, and it is still a big secret to this day. It will greatly help us as we study Zone 3032." Dimitri said, walking to the water fountain. "But for now, make yourselves at home; this will be our main base for the time being." So the four unpacked and began to set up camp; Kushnov marveled over the beauty of the

place. After they finished unpacking and setting up camp, Kushnov and Alex began to unpack the testing equipment. After some work the whole place was made into their new home. Dimitri made dinner, and as they all ate, they talked. "Well, as cool as this place is, I think we should go to bed." Kyle said. "We have a lot of testing and research to do for the next week, so we should probably be well rested. So Kushnov went to bed. This has to be the craziest year of my life, Kushnov thought. Only a few weeks ago I was in a helicopter descending into the Exclusion Zone for the first time, and now I am here, in the actual gosh darn Zone. So Kushnov fell asleep.

Chapter 15

Zone 3032.

Kushnov woke up to a slight draft in the room; when he got up, he noticed that Dimitri was gone, nowhere to be found. He hadn't noticed it at first, but after getting out of bed and getting ready for the day, he noticed that Dimitri was not in the room. For the most part Kushnov just shrugged it off, but after a while he began to wonder where he might be. But before Kushnov could form a plan on what to do about it, Dimitri came into the room through a random tunnel that Kushnov did not recognize. "Good morning, Kushnov," Dimitri said, walking into the center of the room. After Kyle and Alex woke up, Kushnov told them his plans. "I'm going to go into the zone and just look around. I will probably bring the thermal camera, but I just really want to scout out the area." He said. "Fine with me. I and Alex are going to get the equipment ready." Dimitri said. "I will go with you then." Kyle said to Kushnov. As Kushnov got the thermal camera out, Kyle went to pick out the film camera. "Ready when you are, Kushnov." Dimitri said, holding the door handle that opened into Zone 3032. Kushnov and Kyle lined up to go through the door. "Good luck," Alex said, saluting. With that, Dimitri slowly opened the door, revealing overgrown power generators. With a wave of the hand, he bid Kushnov and Kyle walk through. As Kushnov walked past Dimitri, he sensed a little fear from Kyle. He doesn't trust Dimitri, does he? Kushnov thought. Kushnov didn't know if he did either. After a few steps into the abandoned generator room, Kushnov heard the door close and lock. "Let's hope he lets us back in." Kyle said. Kushnov only nodded. For a while Kushnov just walked aimlessly, surveying the room, looking for a staircase or a door. Everything was coated in a thick layer of green, so Kushnov had to poke around and pull the vines back every now and then. After some difficulty, Kyle found a doorway leading to a staircase. He waved Kushnov over. Kushnov got his thermal camera out and started to record. He had plenty of storage drives, so he thought he would just record his whole little trek. As Kushnov walked behind Kyle, his hair started to rise; something was unnerving and creepy about the place. Kushnov at first chalked it up to fear, but after a while he noticed that it was very artificial. He started to notice very cold shapes pop up and dissipate into the ether after rounding a corner of the vast system of hallways. It was a little unnerving, but Kushnov choked up his fear and continued on. He noticed that the greenery slowly turned black as if the life of it was gone, and the carcass of the plants was the only thing left behind. After an hour of walking slowly through the hallways, Kyle started to act odd. He seemed to have a

predetermined course, and Kushnov noticed that when he went one direction, he would feel more fear, but as he went the opposite, he would feel less. Kushnov began to see pockets of sunlight every now and then, but other than that there was only the light from their flashlights to guide them. Then, without warning, Kyle started to bolt, his face pale and full of fear. Kushnov noticed Kyle's heat signature slowly turn blue, and after only a few minutes of running, Kyle stopped. His head slowly turned to reveal a face of some sort of possession. He didn't look like himself; he looked dead. "What's wrong, Kyle?" Dimitri asked. Kyle only mumbled. Kushnov was going to talk when all of a sudden Kyle began to slowly dissipate into nothing; his body slowly disappeared. Kushnov noticed the whole time he hadn't been following Kyle; he had been following some clone of Kyle. Kushnov began to run with speed into the closest room. He was lost and in the most unnerving, scary place he had been in his whole life, and he had no clue what to do now. So he sat down and reviewed the footage, keeping an eye on the doorway of his tiny room. He sat there for many hours watching his recording; something was very off. Kushnov noticed that the time of the recording that was live throughout the recording after a while, without any known reason, started to show time in negative numbers. Other than that, Kushnov didn't notice much; the only other thing that was odd was in the video, for the most part the heat signatures were all normal looking. Kyle's heat signature was a warm red, while most of the walls were blue, but mid-recording, the whole recording was red, and then all the heat signatures flipped. When Kushnov had watched the recording a few times, he formulated a plan. He would retrace his steps. Kushnov first made a path in his mind and, after a little difficulty, made a rough map of his route on paper. His only problem was whether or not he was right. So with that he started his walk back to camp, his AK shouldered and ready for any threats he might meet along the way.

Chapter 16

Alternate Reality.

After a while of walking, Kushnov found himself in the doorway that he and Kyle had gone through first. Before Kushnov walked through, though he started his recording, he had a hunch. As Kushnov walked through, he noticed the thermal camera reset, and the thermal imaging looked normal now, not negative. Kushnov stopped the recording, took a breath of air, and walked towards the center of the room. It was still covered in vines and other greenery, and to him everything was the same; he turned and saw Kyle sitting in the corner. Kyle looked up. "He hasn't responded to my knocks." His face was downcast. Kushnov immediately understood the situation; not only were Kyle and he locked in here with minimal supplies, but Alex was on the other side with Dimitri. "Let's try getting through some other way." Kushnov said, trying to sound confident and under control of his reaction to the news. In reality he was just as freaked out as Kyle, and so he knew he needed to keep his cool in order to make sure the situation didn't get any worse. Kushnov first got his knife out. "Let's cut the vines off this wall; there might be another door." Kushnov said, pulling himself up onto a power generator. Kyle immediately got up and composed himself. Kushnov started to cut the top of the greenery where the ceiling and the wall met. With speed he was able to get half the wall down, and as he cut, Kyle moved the cut part of the plants into a pile in the middle of the room. After some time Kushnov had cleaned the whole wall. He stepped back and sighed. "We're stuck; unless Dimitri changes his mind, we won't be getting out any time soon." He said, resting his head on his hand. "Well, we're in luck," Kyle said, pointing at the wall. "We can just go through that air vent." Immediately Kushnov sprang up. "That's an idea!" He quietly exclaimed. With speed, Kyle got up to the spot where the vent was and started to hit the screws with the butt of his AK. Concrete and dust crumbled, and before long Kyle had removed the first cover. When Kyle poked his head through the vent, he gave Kushnov the thumbs up. Kushnov climbed up and saw Dimitri and Alex walking out of the main room down a hallway. "Now's our time to surprise that idiot." Kyle said. "Let's try to make Dimitri not think we're onto him." Kushnov said. "Let's just act like nothing happened." With that, Kyle took his buttstock and rammed it into the other air duct grill. It gave way, and Kushnov took his gear off. Kushnov crawled through and, after getting through, dropped himself down. "Go ahead and pass me all the gear, and don't forget the camera." As Kyle passed the last of the gear to Kushnov, he went and jumped off the generator and went to grab the camera.

He looked to the side of the room and saw a little blue light slowly getting brighter around the corner. He rushed and grabbed the camera and quickly climbed to the top of the generator; it was an orb. Its blue light lit the room and made it all have a blue tint to it. At first Kyle just watched slowly, thinking it wasn't a threat to him. Kyle slowly pulled the camera up and started to record. But as soon as he had clicked record, the orb moved into the center and into the pile of greenery. It exploded into flames, burning everything in the pile. Kyle stopped the recording and threw it through the duct, the orb coming closer to him. Just as Kyle had stuck his legs in and his head popped out of the air duct hole, the orb got to the hole. Kyle dropped to the ground, muttering to himself. Kushnov had seen it all and decided to just let him just talk to himself. Kushnov slowly took his gear and packed it up, and before long he was in his sleeping bag and resting; he didn't fully close his eyes though. Dimitri walked in with Alex; Kyle quietly chuckled to himself. He looked at Kushnov with a face that said it all. Kushnov got up and walked towards Dimitri.

Chapter 17

Dimitri Tarkov.

“I had quite the experience in the zone,” Kushnov said, walking towards Dimitri. “I want to hear your thoughts on it.” “Sure,” Dimitri said, with a smile. “I would like to speak in private too.” “Gladly.” “See you two in a bit.” Kushnov said. Soon Dimitri and Kushnov were in one of the long passages that led to other rooms and entrances in Moscow. Kushnov stopped walking and stared at Dimitri. But before Kushnov could talk about his experience with losing Kyle and almost getting lost, Dimitri spoke. “You don’t understand,” he said. “You were a fool to think that the Russians would easily let anyone through as easily as we did.” “Why do you say that?” Kushnov asked, confused. “It’s a shame you will never understand.” Dimitri continued. “Before I leave, I will tell you what I know. You must never tell anyone of this conversation, or we’re both screwed. Understand?” Kushnov nodded. “When I left Russia, I went to Ukraine. As you know, I was hired as a scientist to do research. What I never told you was what it was for specifically. The British hired the Ukrainians to do research in Russia for them since they were having very odd activity in London that they traced back to Moscow. At first we researched the zone with very little results and almost no opposition from the Russian forces. We actually never crossed paths with any Russian soldiers until the last trip into Zone 3032. It turns out that the Russians had made up all the stories about the origin of the zone and Zone 3032; they never tried to get free energy or anything of the sort. The whole idea was to find a way to create new things out of nothing.” “To become the creator?” Kushnov asked. “Yes, exactly. To go against the laws of nature and to be the sole creator of something, an intelligence. It turns out that it didn’t go to plan; when the large explosion happened, it happened in the heart of the zone. That was where it all started. We learned that they were taking particles and smashing them into one particle with pure force and hoping to smash new energy into existence. Shame on them for trying because now they created a negated world where IT lives.” “So it’s an alternate universe?” Kushnov asked, not understanding. “No, not exactly.” Dimitri said, looking frantically down the tunnel. “I know what your experience was; you were pulled into a negative version of this world. Most everyone who goes in dies, but lucky for you, you were recording the whole experience, so you were able to retrace your steps. To make it short, the reason your trip was without real opposition was because it was planned, and the last research project like yours didn’t end well.”

Dimitri said, now seeming frantic and concerned. “I wrote a paper on it and the results of the experiment and why it caused the problems in London, and I put it in your bag. Just make sure it makes it to America.” “What are you saying?” Kushnov asked, now very confused. Kushnov couldn’t understand if Dimitri was on his side or another’s side. “You need to get into the zone and survive inside of it if you want to get the research done. I won’t be able to help anymore, and the Russian spetsnaz soldiers will be here to halt your research very soon. Be quick, and I will try to buy you some time.” With that said, Dimitri ran back to the room. Kushnov was running right behind him. Once they got to the room, Dimitri spoke. “Remember what I told you, Kushnov.” And with that, Dimitri left. “We have to get into the zone now.” Kushnov said. Alex and Kyle were confused. “Get the gear in, and I will tell you more later.” Alex and Kyle started to get the door open, and Kushnov started to get the gear into the generator room. After Kushnov had put the last of the gear into the room, he heard sounds down the hallway. It sounded like steps, and they were getting louder. Kushnov squinted and tried to see what it was. Kyle got the flashlight and aimed it down the hallway. “What the heck is that?” Alex said. What they saw was baffling: ten to twenty mutated dog-looking creatures were running down towards them. Alex wasted no time in reacting, and he pulled Kushnov and Kyle in and began to shut it down. “Help me, you idiots!” He yelled. Kushnov and Kyle helped, but the door wouldn’t budge. Kyle ran back and got his AK and began to shoot the oncoming attackers. Before long the dogs were very close, and so Kushnov and Alex also got their guns and started to shoot. Before long the horde of animals had died, and the three were back to getting the door moved. So Kushnov rushed and pushed from the outside. The door moved with ease, and the door closed. “Now how do you get in?” Alex asked. Kushnov was one step ahead of him, though, and before long he had stacked the carcasses of the animals tall enough to reach the vent that they had come out through. Kushnov crawled in. “Let’s get out of here as fast as possible.” Alex said none of them felt like staying in the zone any longer. “We need to complete some more tests, and once we’re done, we can finish.” Kyle said, sitting down. “For now we just have to sleep and continue on.” So the three without Dimitri took turns sleeping. Little did they know this was going to be the least of their troubles.

Chapter 18

Lady of the Zone.

Once all of the friends had rested and all of them felt ready to tackle their tests, the three split up. Kyle would take samples of the composition of the different parts of the zone, while Alex would do all the tests that needed the use of special equipment. Kushnov would trek into the heart of the zone and try to find the heart of it and get exact coordinates of where it was. Kushnov was also in charge of getting all the scientific data out of Russia and back to America. When Alex and Kyle left Kushnov, they got the paper Dimitri was talking about from his bag. It was neatly packed in a cardboard tube, and it had a thumb drive in it. Kushnov thought of reading it, but he told himself he would read it later. Before long Kushnov was occupied with trying to plan out their escape. He was given an old blueprint of the building's air ducts, and he planned on making their escape out with the help of it. But before long he was bored; he wanted to go out and explore. So we got up and took his gear and started to walk down the large array of hallways and offices and other random rooms. As he made his way past doors and other hallways, he would mark on his map his direction, and just to make sure he didn't get lost, he recorded his whole experience. At first Kushnov found, after checking the rooms from time to time that were situated every now and then, that most of them were empty. But as he walked, they would slowly get more filled. It would start with a chair and soon a desk. And after a long time of walking, for what seemed like an hour, he found a specific room. It stood out from among the others. It was a large room with lights, and it had hundreds of office cubicles laid out as far as his eye could see. They were all a little yellow, and all of them were dated; obviously they were very old. Kushnov noticed that there were perfect pathways made that all seemed to go into what looked like the center of the room. Kushnov walked down the path until the lights grew dim and the only thing he could see was the ground. He got his flashlight out and began to notice the eerie silence of the room. Kushnov spotted the center, a large glass statue with light shining on it like it was the center of attention at a ball or some large event. The statue showed a large ring on the outside with waves of water; in the middle of it was a large lady. She was standing on top of what looked like the world, with large Soviet soldiers marching in order. It was eerie, and Kushnov thought he would take a picture with his digital camera. Kushnov backed up and changed the exposure, moved a little, and clicked the button. The sound of the shutter opening and closing sent an echo through the room. When Kushnov saw the photo, it was blurry. What? Why is it so bad?

Kushnov thought. Then he looked up from his camera; the lady's hand moved a little. Kushnov could see things moving in his peripheral vision. Kushnov was no longer interested in the statue, and his only interest now was getting out of the room.

Chapter 19

Scientists of the Zone

Alex thought it would be the best use of time to do the major tests that Camp Vostok had hired them to do; that was to use the AIED machine. The sole purpose of the machine was to extract data on the composition of samples; it was able to measure the amount of protons, neutrons, and electrons in the sample in order to be able to bring back data about the composition of certain organic plants and other things that might have some clues as to what makes the zone a hot spot for anomalies and other odd behaviors. Alex had first walked around for things to sample. After finding a few plants and after getting some samples of the dirt and a few rocks, Alex labeled the samples and unpacked the AIED machine. After booting up the machine, he plugged his computer into it and ran some simple benchmarking tests of default samples to make sure that the machine was not broken and to make sure the tests were as accurate as possible. First Alex loaded a green plant sample that he had found growing in an office space. After loading the sample, he clicked start. The humming of the machine and the moving of servo motors and other parts of it was music to Alex's ears; he had always enjoyed working with electronics and other lab equipment when he was in high school, and after doing his training at Camp Vostok, he had been even more interested in the art. The results after a few minutes came in. Everything looked normal, and the plant Alex theorized was a native *Diplazium sibiricum*, or a mole-ladder. Its composition and age were nothing surprising, and he quickly loaded the next. This time he loaded an odd sample from a red geodelikerock. The first thing that was odd was the fact that it was radioactive with high levels of beta radiation, and since it was just lying on the top of the ground, it must have been thrown there by an explosion or something similar. After loading the sample, Alex pressed the run button, and after the scan was done, Alex was shocked. Not only was its composition unknown and had never been put into the database that was provided with the machine, but its composition was all zero. The overall composition was undetermined, and it seemed like the machine was broken, but after running the test again, it was clear that the machine had not been able to figure anything out about the sample. Alex was discouraged, and he packed up his machine and samples and started to go back to the camp. As he went, he collected more samples for later and, in the process, started to number the samples. After getting back to camp, he opened the storage box that they were provided and began to pack up his samples; at least they would be able to study them once they got back to America.

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Kyle Wolfgang was enjoying his trek through the large rooms full of old machinery and assorted old Soviet tools. Since Kyle's job in the zone was to write scientific notes about the land and to take photos and measurements of interesting places, he found his job very enjoyable. Kyle had always been a fan of photography when he was growing up, and being able to do some fun photography in the zone would calm his nerves. This was perhaps the first time in the zone that he had actually slowed down and started to really sink into the atmosphere. After some time of walking around and snapping some photos here and measuring a few things and noting them in his notebook, he found some odd tracks in the grass inside of a roofless warehouse room. They had a parted hoof-like shape, and the overall size was that of a farm animal. Kyle was never a hunter or tracker, but he recognized that these tracks were fresh, very fresh to be exact, and he didn't want to miss the opportunity of taking a few photos of the wildlife and other living things that were around Zone 3032. So Kyle took advantage of the opportunity and began to track it. At first Kyle thought it was just a dog or some other animal, but after following the tracks for only half an hour, he found that it was a truly random pattern. Kyle was not very encouraged and started to walk back to camp, thinking it was a waste of time. But before Kyle started to turn and go the direction he came, he caught sight of a creature staring back at him through some dark corners of the room he was in. Kyle shrugged it off, thinking he was getting tired or something, and he quickly started to walk back, but after getting halfway back to camp, he noticed it was following him. He took a sharp turn into a corner and took out his camera and prepared for a shot of whatever this thing was. His heart started to beat fast, and his breathing became slow but consistent; he was genuinely scared of what he might see come around the corner. Slowly he heard the creature creep down the hall; Kyle was ready now to take a picture and to run. The creature stopped, the shadow cast down in front of Kyle's hiding spot outside the hallway in a small room, and the shadow disappeared into thin air. Kyle was freaked out, and now he started to bolt back to camp. He had gathered all the data he wanted, and now his plan was to make it back to safety.

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After Kushnov got back to camp, he found Kyle and Alex; they were discussing the best course of action. "We should really just stay one more day and leave." Kyle said. "We already have plenty of data that will keep the scientists busy for years." "We haven't even gotten a terabyte of data yet; the photos and videos along with all the notes have only taken a few hundred gigabytes." Alex said. "What do you think, Kushnov?" Kyle asked. "I think we should stay a little longer. We need to do a little more research, and there are a few questions I need answered." "So a few more days?" "Exactly. Just a few more." Kushnov's reply quieted the room; it seemed bleak, and even Kushnov didn't

feel safe in Zone 3032 anymore. “We need to figure out where the center of Zone 3032 is and how we might be able to push back and halt the expanding Exclusion Zone in general.” “Why don’t we all go together then?” Alex asked. “I don’t think we’re going to last long if we’re all apart.” “Sounds good to me.” Kyle responds, sitting down on his bed. “For now though I’m going to rest; I have a hunch the heart of the zone is not close.” So Kyle went to bed, and Kushnov and Alex talked for a while. “I found this odd statue an hour-plus walk away,” Kushnov said. “I think it definitely is worth trying to get back out of the zone.” “What did it look like?” Alex asked. Kushnov got out his camera and started to look at the library of photos he had taken. He found it and showed Alex. “Tried to take a photo, but it ended up all blurry and odd. Actually ended up running out of the place because of how creepy it was; there is definitely a lot of activity there.” “That’s exactly what we need, a lot of activity and odd stuff.” Alex said, clicking his fingers in a happy tone. “Tomorrow we take some gear and go there. I bet the heart of the zone is near that area if the activity is that crazy. Until then, goodnight.” Alex ended up going to his bed and starting to get some sleep. Kushnov just sat there; he didn’t feel like he had the stomach for it, and he definitely didn’t like being in Zone 3032. Thus Kushnov went to bed, his mind processing the last few days of his life in the zone. It was all odd.

Chapter 20

Room 44.

When Kushnov got up, he found Kyle and Alex getting ready for the trek. Alex had already told Kyle the plans, so Kushov just got his gear and began to pack all the extra stuff he might need. Kushnov first grabbed a few more memory cards for the cameras, and he also grabbed the film camera along with them. Alex had already grabbed the AIED machine, and Kyle had already packed the blank scientist notebook that the Artifact Incorporation had given them. So, without anything else to grab, Kushnov led his friends to the room that they would be spending the day in. As they made their way, Kushnov and Klye talked for a while while Alex wrote down some notes. It was clear to Kushnov that Alex was going to be leading the research once they got to the room, and so Kushnov would step back from leading them for the day once they had established a game plan.

After an hour of walking, Kushnov stopped. They had arrived at their destination, and it was time to commence the research. Alex walked into the room and turned his headlamp on, with Kushnov and Kyle close behind. The air seemed cooler than when Kushnov had first walked in; the room also seemed more at rest. Alex started to walk towards a random cubicle. He opened the drawer and found some pencils and an unused notepad. Alex slowly walked into the center of the room, checking each cubicle for any changes in size or anything, for that matter. Alex looked ahead and spotted the statue Kushnov had seen the day before. The three friends walked towards it and began to unpack. This was where Alex wanted to focus their time. "Kushnov," Alex said. "I want you to take some measurements and notes on this thing; heck, you can even make a drawing of it. Kyle, I want you to take a few photos with the digital camera. And while you're at it, film and also just take a video with the thermal camera. Let's try to collect a lot of data on this object. I will bust out the AIED and get the ground- penetrating radar system and try to get a scan of the floor and anything that might be underneath us." With that, they all got to work unpacking and setting up lights for the area. Kyle got out the cameras and a few tripods and began to set the cameras up. Kushnov got some portable lights from his bag and set them up in the perimeter so that they could see. He also put his NVGs on his helmet just in case he needed them.

Before long, Alex had unpacked all the instruments and began to set them up. Kyle helped Alex while Kushnov got some drawings and measurements in his notebook.

Kushnov was not good at drawing, but he tried his best. After Alex had set up the GPS, he began to scan; this would hopefully show if there were any tunnels or structures in the ground that they could not see. After some time of the scanner spinning the laser around so the lenses could collect some data, the results came in. There appeared to be a cavity that was right under the statue. Kushnov walked over towards the statue. "I think it's an entrance. We just need to figure out how to get in." "Easy for you to say." Kyle said. Alex saved the scan on his computer and walked over. "Let's do this quietly." "Do what?" Kushnov said, not wishing to damage the statue. "Let's blow that stupid thing up!" Kyle said, not caring to take any longer to get inside the secret cavity under it. "Let's cut it off first. Kushnov, get the saw, please. The faster the better," Alex said. Kushnov walked over to Alex's bag and grabbed the saw. "I don't think the zone will react nicely to us cutting this statue. So I think we should be ready to run in and get some data and sprint out of here. I'm sure the scientists at Artifact Inc. will be more than happy with the data we've collected." Alex said. "Definitely, we should bring the statue with us too. I think it has some important role in Zone 3032 and the zone in general." Kyle said. "Well then, let's get to it." Kushnov said, not wanting to take any more time talking.

Kushnov began to cut the statue with the new blade. The noise echoed around the room. Kyle stood guard while Alex got the explosives ready; nobody wanted to take too long. After Kushnov finished cutting off the lady of the zone (as Kushnov called it), Alex stepped up and applied the C4. Kushnov packaged the statue with paper and put it in his bag. Once Alex was done, Kyle and Kushnov methodically cleaned up everything they would need to take back to the extraction zone and got ready to run in and stand guard while Alex took notes and scans of the underground structure. Alex gave the signal to stand back, and Kushnov walked halfway to the door; he started to record. Kyle stepped behind an office cubicle, and Alex took a few steps into the swarm of filing cabinets near Kushnov. Alex flipped up the safety on the switch and pushed the button. The sound was deafening, and dust filled the air.

Chapter 21

Sparta and Scorpion.

As soon as the dust had cleared from the detonation, Kushnov ran over to the hole with the camera in hand; it was clear that they had found an important entrance to some unknown place. Alex gave the signal to stay quiet, and he jumped in. Kyle followed, and Kushnov was close behind. When Kushnov jumped in, he found his feet firmly planted on a concrete walkway; it was an entrance to a tunnel. Alex looked back and inspected his old map and started to walk down the long tunnel. Kushnov kept watch behind them, and Kyle planted waypoints on his INS so that they could find their way out if they needed to get back out the way they came. After some time of walking, Alex motioned for Kushnov to come up, and Alex whispered in Kushnov's ear. "I think we're at the end of it." He said, pointing towards the end of the hallway. "Tell Kyle to put on his NVGs and to put away the INS. I don't want any of us to be caught off guard." With that, Kushnov walked back towards Kyle, who was messing around with his Inertial Navigation System. Kushnov whispered in his ear. "Alex said to drop the INS and get your NVGs on and to also get ready for any possible threats." "Alright, give me a second." Kyle responded, putting the INS in his pocket and flipping his NVGs on. Kushnov tapped Alex on the back, and they started to walk towards the end, guns shouldered in a single-file formation. Kushnov's heart was pounding. Alex sank into the side of the wall and motioned for Kushnov and Kyle to do the same. Kushnov could see Russian Sparta Group soldiers pass the opening of the hallway, casually walking. They didn't seem to have noticed the large blast sound, or maybe they had but didn't think to check that tunnel.

Kushnov pulled up his mask and walked up to the part where the two tunnels met; he looked left, then right. Alex came up and motioned for Kyle to follow. Kushnov led Alex and Kyle down the opposite way that the Sparta soldiers had gone, and before long, they found a smaller room with a blast door off the side of the underground hallway. Kushnov shifted inside the room with Kyle and Alex close behind. He scanned the room; nothing. Kyle leaned over and whispered to Kushnov. "I bet they were out on patrol. Perhaps they are protecting something, perhaps something important." "Definitely sounds right," Kushnov responded. "Let's close the door and get our gas masks on, and while we're at it, let's scan for radio channels that have activity." Alex and Kyle nodded and began their work.

Alex got his RF spectrum analyzer out, and Kyle closed the door shut. Alex motioned for Kushnov to come over. “Lots of activity on the S-band frequency and also in the EHF frequency, which is about 30 to 300 MHz. Don't know what it means, but it's definitely worth putting in the notes.” Kushnov nodded and returned to his position in the corner of the room. He dug out his gas mask and put it on, adjusting his NVGs for the mask's clear visor. “Check this out,” Kyle said, turning his flashlight onto the door; it bore a logo of the Scorpion. They were the Russian scientists that operated in the Exclusion Zone. “Good eye,” Kushnov said. “Let's take some photos of that. Don't take too long, though; I want to move on so that we don't waste time here.” “Definitely, we should take advantage of not having the whole darn zone coming after us right now.” Kushnov stepped back and picked up his AK. Alex got up and put his mask on, making sure to adjust his goggles. They were ready to move on.

Kushnov opened the door slowly and turned his HUD on; data was spewed everywhere on his goggles. The data his goggles displayed was, for the most part, useless; Kushnov only wanted it on for the LiDAR map. The LiDAR map showed Kushnov what the overall size and look of the room or hallway was; it was very nice since it also showed where Alex and Kyle were, something he needed to keep track of. Kushnov began his walk down the hall with Alex and Kyle right behind him. For what seemed like half an hour, Kushnov led them through the long tunnel that seemed to weave to and fro at random. For the most part, the tunnel seemed deserted. Once Kushnov had walked for more than an hour, he started to notice the tunnel seemed to get wider, and before long after that, Kushnov spotted in the distance a light. He turned his HUD off and flipped his NVGs up. He squinted down the hallway. It seemed as if there was something down there, but Kushnov couldn't seem to tell what. Alex stepped in front of Kushnov, noticing the same thing, for that was what it was to them: a thing. Alex started to walk slowly towards the light, and once he got there, he noticed more lights lining the tunnel. Not long after that they had made it to one last large blast door, large enough to pass a large truck through. Kushnov spotted a smaller door for people just at the bottom and began to tug it open. Kushnov gave a tug, and the door reluctantly swung open; a large amount of blue light hit their eyes, blinding them.

Chapter 22

Eminent Danger.

Once Kushnov's eyes adjusted to the light, he couldn't believe what he was seeing: there were lab-coated scientists conducting tests in what was a makeshift lab with Sparta soldiers standing watch in the upper levels of the room. Kushnov quickly slipped in with Alex and Kyle close behind; they stayed in the shadows, trying not to cause a stir. Kushnov led the way, weaving in and behind large storage boxes that stood in the corners of the room. Once Kushnov had gotten to the other side of the room, he formulated a plan; he would have to get some photos and get out fast. Kyle, reading Kushnov's mind, got his stealth camera out. The shutter made the faintest noise as it clicked a few times; none of the scientists or the guards seemed to notice. Kushnov gave one last look at the guards before going down an unmarked hallway. The lights flickered as Kushnov led the way. Alex saw a guard slowly walking down towards them; Alex motioned for Kushnov and Kyle to follow him into a random room. Kushnov saw the guard walk by, oblivious to the three friends' presence. Kushnov gave a sigh of relief. His attention now was put towards the room they had walked into.

The room was pitch black, and it seemed to Kushnov to be used for storage; he turned on his NVGs and HUD. The whole room was lit by his goggles, and he found to his amazement that the whole room was full of tiny crates. This was odd to Kushnov because all the boxes were sealed shut, and all of them bore the symbol of the Scorpion. "Are you seeing this, Kyle?" Kushnov asked. "Yeah." Kyle responded, holding his camera up. "I've already taken a few photos. Why don't we pop one open?" Kushnov got out his multi-tool and began to pry open the crate. Alex came over and helped pry the top. With the crate open, Kushnov could see what it contained: hundreds of perfectly packed samples in labeled vials. "Hey Alex, do you have any extra room in your pack?" Alex took his backpack off and began to unzip the middle zipper. "You want me to steal the samples?" He said. "Well, we're only borrowing them." Kyle answered for Kushnov. Kushnov and Alex began to pick out samples that they didn't recognize and tossed them into Alex's bag. "Ok, let's get out of here." Kyle said, uninterested in looking into the rest of the boxes. Kyle began to head for the door. Once he made it to the door, he slowly opened the peephole and looked outside. He jumped back as a soldier slowly walked past. "I've got an idea." Alex said, going towards a wall with an air duct that didn't have any storage racks or boxes against it. "Let's take the air ducts, just like in the metro." He

began to unscrew the screws holding the grate. Kyle jumped over and began to help. Kushnov stood behind, keeping watch of the door. "Got it!" Alex said, slowly pushing the grate out of the way. Kushnov poked his head in. "Alex, you lead the way. Kyle, stay right behind me. Let's try to be as quiet as possible; there's no really easy way to get out of an air duct without knowing the layout of the building." Alex scrambled in, and Kushnov began to follow. Kyle pulled the grate back behind them and soon caught up with Alex and Kushnov. The air duct was very dusty, and Kushnov started to have to constantly wipe the dust off his gas mask so he could see; it was grueling. Alex led Kushnov and Kyle through the vast system of ducts, and they were soon near another grate. The only problem was that there was no way to get out without blasting the grate off and making a bunch of noise. Alex motioned for Kushnov to come up. "We're probably going to blow our cover, but I don't think we have any other chance. We can't stay in here forever." Alex whispered. Kushnov thought for a second. But how much better of a chance do we have out there? He thought. Kushnov didn't plan on taking too long to make a decision. "Let's blast it." He said, now wanting to have a reason to get out of the underground complex. Alex nodded and relayed the plan to Kyle. Kushnov took the buttstock on his AK and started to hit the corners of the grate; it didn't budge, and the noise filled the air duct. "It's not working," Kushnov said, panicking a little. "I got this." Kyle said, walking up with some small blast charges. Kyle put the charges near where the screws were and crawled back to the safe area, away from the blast. "Ready?" He whispered. "Yup," Alex said. Kushnov didn't feel ready, but he still said yes. "Three. Two. One." The shock from the blast went through Kushnov, and before long he felt disoriented and unprepared; he began to follow Kyle and Alex as they crawled out. Dust filled the air, and his goggles began to fog up as his breathing became fast. Kushnov shouldered his AK and began to scan the room; it was an empty room about the size of a normal living room in an apartment. Alex ran over towards the door and peeked through the peephole; nobody. "Let's try to get out of here fast." Kushnov said, not caring about stealth anymore. "Alright, let's try to get up to the surface." Alex said.

Kyle and Alex led the way as they opened the door and began to tactically run down the complex's hallway. They soon got to a larger opening with a tall ceiling. Kushnov ran to the middle of the room and started his LASAMS. A Large Area Scanning And Mapping System that used high-frequency sounds to map a room the same way a bat sees when it can't actually see with its eyes. After a few seconds the HUD spat out a spinning 3D model that spun over Kushnov's visor; it was a big room with 10 or maybe 20 different hallways, but one was bigger than the others. "Let's take that one." He said, using his IR laser to show Alex and Kyle where he was pointing. Alex and Kyle began to run over towards the entrance to the large truck-sized tunnel. Kushnov suspected that it would eventually lead to a parking lot or someplace that cars could enter and exit the base; hopefully, that would also have an entrance to the surface. Kushnov left his

scanner on and began to run ahead of Alex and Kyle, and before long he was much further than his friends, his adrenaline pushing him on. Kushnov stopped and saw the tunnel rise up. Finally, someplace closer to the surface. Kushnov waved for Alex and Kyle's attention; they looked over and saw what Kushnov saw. They all began to run with haste towards the rise of the tunnel, their hopes rising with it. Once they got there, they saw an endless staircase following the road up. "Let's take a break; we might need to run for it once we get up there." Kyle said, sitting down at the very first step of the never-ending staircase. The three all sat down; they began to catch their breath as they took their gas masks off. A shrieking siren sound began to blast through the whole complex; their presence was now known. Red sirens began to spin and color the whole complex in red light. "Change of plans." Kushnov said, pulling on his gas mask and getting up. "Let's get going." He said as he started to run up the stairs. Alex and Kyle began to get ready, and soon they were halfway up the tunnel.

Kushnov looked back to his horror to see 50-plus guards running at a breakneck speed with a security UTV close behind; it looked bleak. "Watch out." Kyle yelled as the three began to receive fire from the guards shooting their AKs. Bullets hit the road but not any of the three friends. Kushnov threw a smoke grenade down towards the guards, and Alex followed it with a normal grenade. The two grenades drifted in the air, and once they hit the ground, they slowly rolled towards the guards. Before the guards could react, the gas exploded, sending a cloud of white eye-burning gas into the guards' faces. The normal grenade exploded, probably killing half the guards who were not prepared for the three trespassers to fight back. Kushnov got to the top and signaled for Kyle to lay all the explosives he had on the smaller blast door since it was locked.

Kyle got to work as Kushnov and Alex began to fire shots back at the guard. Kushnov got hit in the helmet but didn't suffer any bad harm, but the guards slowly fell one by one. This was the first time Kushnov had shot at people, and he didn't feel good about it; he really only wanted to get away, so he mostly tried to only shoot the parts that didn't mortally wound the guards. Still, Kushnov shot, and after only a few seconds, Kyle was ready to blast the door off. "Get ready!" Kyle yelled, running to the other side of the tunnel and bracing for the blast that would come with the explosion. Kushnov heard the ear-blistering blast that echoed through the room; the guards stopped as they heard the blast too. Then Kushnov heard the intercom click on. "All stations report to Sector Nine: security breach and threat escaping the complex. Status Red Alert!" The intercom shut off, and the alarms continued. Kushnov didn't wait longer, and neither did Alex nor Kyle. The three ran past the door and saw the sunlight. Kushnov turned his HUD off and fully flipped his NVGs off. Pulling his gas mask up, he gave orders to his friends. "Alex, activate the emergency extraction beacon and turn it on so Camp Vostok can see our movements in the sky. Kyle, get the maps ready and give us an escape route; we have to

get to Dubna and fast. Once we get there, we can board the light rail and hopefully get to the extraction point. And Alex, let's get satellite communication with Artifact; we're probably going to need Molly's help if we want to get out of here." Molly was the lady at Artifact Inc. whose job was to help the three friends get out of Russia, along with the scientific data.

Kushnov began to run towards where his GPS watch told him. Kyle and Alex are close behind, keeping watch of behind them. The guards were at the main complex, rallying a response team to eliminate the trespassers. Kushnov pulled on his gas mask and pulled the filters off; he wouldn't need them anyway. His HUD flashed a progress bar that showed the satellite communication status. After a little wait, the satellite showed a checkmark. "How's the mission going?" the voice on the satellite communication link asked. Kushnov looked back at Kyle and Alex behind him. "Could be better. We're being chased by Sparta guards, and we're 60 miles away from Light Rail." "Great!" Molly said in a sarcastic tone. "Let's get you guys back home; I will get the extraction team ready for your airlift. Be right back." The mike clicked off. Kushnov started to pick up his pace as he prepared for the long jog to the Light Rail. The Light Rail was a special rail system that was operated by the rebels in the Exclusion Zone. The Light Rail was a fast system that went under the ground for 400 miles towards the border with Finland. The rail system was very modern, and the whole train was able to make the trip from Dubna to the city of Vyborg in only 24 hours. "They're getting ready; they will be ready in about 12 hours, and their ETA at Vyborg is in about 29 hours. So no rush." Molly said, in a cool, calm tone. "Thanks," Kushnov said. "Looks like we're going to be losing our link soon." Alex said, chiming in to the conversation. "Alright, we'll keep you guys updated as you go. We have a stolen Russian Tigr operated by bandits ready for you guys once you get out of Moscow. Stay safe." Molly signed off.

Chapter 23

The Escape.

Kushnov began to feel tired as the night sank into place. His data link with the Artifact satellite spat data onto his HUD. When he looked back, he could see the helicopters at the secret Zone 3032 bunker complex get ready for takeoff; for now, the three had the lead. Kyle chimed in on the radio channel. "We should be at the Tigr truck in half an hour or so." He said. "I don't know if I can make it there in one jog, though. Let's take a break." "We can't, though; we have to keep our lead in front of the Sparta guards." Alex said, taking the words out of Kushnov's mouth. "We can take a short break." Kushnov said. "But we don't have enough time. We really have to get to the truck; once we're inside, we can rest." Kushnov felt the same way as Kyle; his brain screamed for rest, but he also knew he couldn't afford one. Kushnov stopped and pulled out his bag. "Here, have my MEG (Military Energy Gum). I can stand without it." Kushnov tossed the packet to Kyle. Kyle tore the packaging apart and threw the gum into his mouth. The three sat down and caught their breath. Kushnov's HUD gave an alarm; the helicopters had taken off and were almost ready for their search and destroy mission. "Ok, let's go," Kushnov said, getting up. "No time now to waste." Alex responded. Kushnov could see the location of the truck and of the helicopter; it seemed as if the helicopter got closer faster than they got closer to the escape truck. But before Kushnov began to doubt if they would make it, he could see the truck in the distance, the back open and ready to receive the new passengers. As soon as the three saw the truck, they picked up their pace. Just as Kushnov got to the truck, he could hear the small crew of three greet the new passengers. "Good day, comrades!" a man yelled, helping Kushnov take his pack off and putting it in the back of the truck. "Almost started to leave without you," another said, joking. "I've had any type of day other than good." Kyle said, throwing his bag down and opening the door to the Tigr. "Well then, hopefully you enjoy your ride with us," the third said, casually opening the other doors. The helicopter was now in view; it was an MI-28, a Russian attack helicopter with an autocannon that could easily destroy the trucks' armor. Behind it was a Kanzan Ansar, a light helicopter that was probably full of Spartan soldiers. "No time to waste now." One of the bandits said, jumping into the driver's seat. The truck eased onto the roadway. "What are your names?" One of the men asked. "My name is Alex, and these two tired fellows are Kushnov and Kyle." Alex said. "Hi," Kushnov said, dead tired. Kyle only mumbled a faint greeting. "My name is Artom. This is Nikolai and Korsakov." "Good

day, gentlemen,” Nikolai said. “Happy to be your driver, I suppose.” Korsakov said, looking back with a fake frown at the three passengers. “For now you guys can get some rest; hopefully our trance electronic music doesn’t distract you.” Nikolai said, putting a USB with the name MUSIC in bold inside the makeshift audio system. “Fun fact, we three came to the Exclusion Zone so we could collect long-forgotten music from deserted Russian houses and clubs.” “It’s very fun to go treasure hunting with the orbs or mutated creatures hot on your heels.” Nikolai said. Kushnov was uninterested. Kushnov, for a moment, felt safe, but reality struck when he heard the MI-28 autocannon fire towards the truck. Korsakov swerved out of the path of the exploding projectiles fired from the helicopter. Kushnov bolted up. “Hey, Kushnov,” Artom yelled. “You grab me that RPG in the back; it should be right behind you.” He continued in a chill tone. Kushnov shifted his weight and looked behind him. Digging the RPG out, he grabbed it along with a few extra rockets. “No need to grab any more; I always make my shots.” Artom yelled back. “Alright then.” Kushnov said, handing the loaded RPG to Artom. Artom grabbed it and began to back into his seat, the truck jolting every now and then with Korsakov driving. Artom dug out a pack of cigarettes and lit one. “Watch the professional,” Nikolai said, rolling his eyes. Artom opened the window and popped out. Artom took aim and fired. The missile made a direct hit, and the helicopter exploded in flames as it fell to the ground. “Like I said, never miss my shots.” Artom passed the RPG back to Kushnov. “That should slow them down.” Korsakov said, easing off the gas pedal. Kushnov nodded and looked out the window.

Chapter 24

City of Dubna.

Kushnov watched as the scenery changed from a large city to a small town and eventually to a dark, deep forest that seemed to choke out any light that dared to enter. But not long after that, the sun had set, and the whole world was covered in a dark veil. The headlights of the Tigr military truck were the only thing that helped them see what was in front of them. The Russian Sparta soldiers had left and regrouped, or at least that's what Molly had told Kushnov. The intelligence was sometimes unreliable, and in this moment Kushnov was prepared for the worst. With the destruction of a helicopter and an apparent security threat to the complex in Sector Nine, the Russians were probably furious. "It seems like the Russians haven't given up yet; intelligence reports show that the Russians are arming some Su-75 Checkmates and plan on deploying them towards Dubna. It seems the Russians don't suspect, to our knowledge, that you three were sent over by any other nations, just bandits causing trouble. Let's keep your status that way." Molly said. "I will give you guys an intelligence report in one hour. Good work." The satellite connection terminated. Kushnov sat and reloaded his AK mags and got ready for the scramble into the Dubna Light Rail. The Russians probably had fitted the Su-75 with bunker-busting explosives, and they probably were not afraid to use it. Kushnov woke up Alex and filled him in on the overall situation. "It seems bleak, but once we make it on the Light Rail, we should be good. Unless the Russians are keeping watch on the air traffic near Vyborg." "Alrighty then, we should get rid of all the stuff we don't need to keep or immediately take with us. Such as rations or other perishables and any testing equipment." "Well, we can't actually; if the Russians find our gear after taking out a bandit outpost, then they will probably be able to find the origin of it. All we need to do is get all the gear and stuff back to America, and then we're good. The politicians and ambassadors will take care of the rest of it." "Well, for now then, I guess we should just get ready to run for it." "Indeed." Korsakov said. "We will need to get underground and out of the city as soon as possible; our thermal heat trail will be visible for miles from the sky, and since it isn't too cold right now, it will last very long. That Su-75 Checkmate will definitely be able to see us and take out the light rail before we get there if they think they need to deploy a bunker buster." "Why would they deploy a bunker buster?" Alex asked. "Since they don't really know how long you guys were in the complex, they probably will keep it a secret at all costs. So if you guys are working for a government, which you are but the Sparta soldiers don't know that, then

you're definitely a big security threat." "Thanks, I guess I didn't think of that." Alex responded, looking at his GPS and watching the city of Dubna get closer and closer. Kushnov got a little rest, and in no time they were at the border of Dubna. Korsakov drove into a parking garage that was still in okay condition and drove to the lowest level underground. Once Korsakov parked, he got out and gave commands to his two friends. "Nikolai and Artom, I want you guys to close the blast door to this level of the parking garage. You three, get your gear on and take a seat on the bench." Kushnov got out and stretched a little and opened the back of the truck, grabbing his bag and gear. He put it on and adjusted it, making sure it all was good to go. Kyle and Alex got out and did the same, and before long the three friends were sitting on a bench in a parking garage with some destroyed and abandoned cars and a crazy Russian bandit in a military truck smoking a cigar. "I'm cultured; unlike Artom, the fine cigars of Russia are much better than the junky cigarettes that Artom gets. Nikolai doesn't drink or smoke; he just likes to listen to music. In my opinion, we are a somewhat normal gang for being Russian bandits living in the Exclusion Zone." "Very normal," Kyle said. Nikolai and Artom returned with some news. "We got the level closed, and we're ready to get out of here." Artom said, flicking his cigarette out of his mouth and crumbling it beneath his feet. "What next, Karsakov?" Nikolai asked. "Next we're going to Light Rail; once there, we will get the gear packed up and ready for extraction." Karsakov responded. "Let's go then." Kyle responded, seeming more rested and ready for the rest of the trip. Kushnov followed Artom as he weaved his way through the parking garage and to the surface of the city. "Keep a low profile, and if I start running, then just run." Artom said, crouching as he looked out the main entrance to the garage. The city of Dubna was in somewhat good condition for a city in the zone. It had only been deserted for 5 years, and since the Russians still used it every now and then for military purposes, it was still maintained for a few years after its desertion. Kushnov crouched behind Artom with his bag and gear weighing him down as the slight sprinkle of rain fell on Kushnov's gas mask. The sky was dark and cloudy, and the city was clouded in a misty fog. Kushnov could see the Su-75's movement as it went on a normal search pattern on his HUD map. Kushnov could also see a few helicopters that were used for transporting troops coming his direction from a smaller base on the outskirts of Moscow. "It seems like we're probably going to get found if we don't move any faster." Kushnov said, looking at his GPS and HUD. "Fine then. Run for it." Artom said, starting to jog towards the train station. Halfway to the train station, Kushnov heard a slight ear-piercing sound coming from the sky; a Su-75 Checkmate flew past through the clouds, its jet engines making a loud rumble as its afterburners turned on and it came in for another pass. "Think it found us!" Alex yelled, starting to run at breakneck speed. "If it gets another pass on us and tracks our location, it won't have any difficulty destroying the train station." "Let's move on then!" Nikolai responded. The group started for the train station as fast as possible.

Kushnov was pulled into a large building by Artom. The rest split into the other buildings that were closer to them. “If they find us, we’re dead meat.” Artom whispered. “Let’s stay in here for a few minutes and try to make him think we got to another part of the city. Whatever keeps him guessing.” Kushnov sat down behind a cash register and began to track the helicopter movement that was in the city; it seemed like they were trying to find a good spot to land. Kushnov poked his head out and saw the train station entrance a few hundred feet away. “We’re good to go.” Artom said. Kushnov started to run towards the entrance. He looked back and saw the rest of his friends coming to. Kushnov got to the entrance and looked back, ready to fire. His ears were filled with the loud sound of rotor blades and jet engines in the sky; an Mi-26 descended onto the road on the other side of the street. Russian soldiers started pouring out of the helicopter as the helicopter kicked up dust and rocks all over the place.

Chapter 25

The Light Rail.

“Get in!” Kushnov yelled as Kyle and Alex, with the others, began to run faster. They got inside the entrance and crouched. “Did they see us?” Kyle asked. “Of course, you idiot! Look, we don’t have any more time to waste; we have to get inside.” Korsakov said, running down the stairs into the train station. After the six friends had gotten inside the actual station, they were led by Korsakov into a maintenance room. It was a secret door, and once they had made it through, they could see it. The light rail train car was shaped like a bullet and looked fast. “Welcome, friends.” A man said, waving. “As you know, we’re in lockdown right now with the troops near, so we won’t be leaving for a few hours then. We’re ready to, though, so just throw your bags and gear in, and once we have it all under control, we will be on our way.” “We don’t have any time to wait; there is a Russian Su-75 out there with Russian soldiers on the ground with the ability to coordinate a bunker buster that can destroy this whole complex. So if you want us all to die, then I would say get a move on.” Artom yelled. “I—I didn’t know we would be on our own at a full retreat.” The man responded. “All stations prepare for evacuation in 3 minutes and get on the LR train. I repeat, evac in 3 minutes.” He continued on his microphone, giving orders to the people around them. Kushnov ran into the train and put his gear down and prepared for the train's abrupt departure. The train closed its doors, and it began its routine checks, making sure it was in safe operating status. The intercom clicked on. “All passengers, get ready for rapid acceleration in 20 seconds.” Kushnov sat down on a bench and held on to the handles inside of the train car. The train jolted forward; Kushnov's body was pushed into his seat. Kushnov looked at all the other passengers; they looked like they had been on this train hundreds of times. The train sped along the tracks, and once it got up to speed in the loop that helped the train get momentum, it flipped on the tracks that led to Vyborg. Once the train made another loop, it would start its trip. The reason the train had to make loops was because of the specific way the train sped up. It was made so that it would not waste a lot of energy speeding up. So it worked by using a large system of magnets that would pull the train along in the tracks, eventually catapulting it out to its destination. Once it was at a consistent speed, Kushnov made his way to the back of the train. The train car was open, and he could feel the wind speeding past him. It was surprisingly calm other than the clicking of the train tracks and the shifting wind. The train made its

last pass by the loading bay, and after it had cleared the dock, the lights turned off so as to save the energy for the last push of the train onto the tracks that led to Vyborg. But before Kushnov could return, a large blast filled the tracks as a bunker buster bomb inserted itself into the train system. Rocks fell on the train, and Kushnov, along with the other passengers on the open-decked train car, lost consciousness.

Alex was working on his computer; he wanted to make sure that once they got to America, the data would be easy to transfer to the large Artifact database that was located in a remote region somewhere in Alaska near Camp Vostok. All Alex had to do before the upload was to label every piece of data and to put it in file folders so that the scientists would be able to easily access it. Alex was in a train car with smaller office-like cubicles. He had gone there to focus and get some rest. The other people in there were only writing small papers or other things that they wanted published in the outside world. Alex felt the train speed up after the captain spoke, and before long the lights went out. Alex jumped up as he heard the loud blast and the rocks hitting the top of the train. "All stations, a bunker buster has been deployed to our location; stay inside and report any damage to the train." Alex made his way back to the main train car.

Kyle was restless; being stuck in a train car with a bunch of crazy Russians smoking was not his cup of tea, and since he didn't like being in crowded places, he went to the front of the train to the actual part where the engineer was operating it. All the train cars were older-looking and boxy; some had plated armor on the sides. The second to last traincar was very nice and modern with an aerodynamic shape and nice new paint job; it was very comfortable, to say the least, but it was mostly full of the important people and gear that needed to stay safe. The actual locomotive was very modern with a large amount of armor and batteries along with a diesel engine for emergencies. It was all very nice, and Kyle liked being alone in the train with the operators. "How's your day been?" A random man asked Kyle. "I've had better, but for the most part it's been very eventful." Kyle responded. "How about you?" "Very fun day; woke up to an alarm in our bunker complex telling us all that some soldiers were patrolling the area and that we needed to be on guard. Other than that, somewhat normal. Anyway, have a good day." The man left for the other train cars. Kyle looked out the bulletproof window and heard a large blast noise and crumbling concrete. The Su- 75 had fired its bunker buster, and if Artom hadn't told the main man leading the operation, they probably would have been crushed or blown up. Kyle began to run back to check on the rest of his friends.

Kushnov woke up to see a few people on the ground with him. The train continued its route, but the people in the back were hurt. Kushnov looked and saw a little wound on his leg and got out his emergency medical pack to fix it up. He finished and helped a few people up. He headed back for the main train car to check in on the rest of his friends. "Hey there, Kushnov, are you good?" Alex asked. "Fine now, but I got a little

wound in my leg; it should be fine though.” “That’s good.” Kyle said. “Well, it could be worse, and for now we’re safe. So I guess we can hang out and perhaps play some cards.” Alex said, pulling a handmade deck of cards out of his pocket. “Made these while we were in the zone with the extra paper and stuff we had; pretty good if you ask me.” He said, putting the cards on the ground. Kushnov made some space and began to play a little poker with some random bottle caps and other things that were in replacement of poker chips. They sat for a while and played a few games. Kushnov got up after the third game. “I’m tired; I’m going to take a rest.” Kushnov said he noticed nobody was in the beds in the train car. “See you guys later.” “See ya,” Kyle said. Kushnov walked down and began to slip into the bed with all his gear. At least I can get some rest, he thought. Sleep took him in as a guest, and he soon fell asleep.

Chapter 26

Extraction at Vyborg.

Kushnov woke up to Alex pushing him awake. “Almost there, Kushnov, and we need to get ready.” Kushnov got up and followed Alex to the train car that had all the gear. He found Artom, Korsakov, Nikolai, and Kyle there already. “Your ride should be ready once we get there, and once you guys get inside the jeep, our job is done.” Korsakov said. “Thank you guys for coming to the zone to take some actual scientific data back to America; hopefully all the time was well spent and the true facts about the Zone could be brought to light.” “We hope so too, and thank you guys for helping us.” Kushnov said. “Wouldn’t have made it heard without you guys, so thanks again.” The train made its way to the loading dock and made a stop. “All are free to disembark the train.” A Russian man yelled, walking down the train cars to make sure the rest of the people would get the message. Kushnov walked off and saw the large groups of bandits and government workers from other countries talking and selling; it was an underground market. Kushnov walked up the stairs with a slow limp because of his leg, and once he got to the top, he saw the light from the streetlights and the moon. The streets were clean, and there were people walking around with their guns patrolling. It was the first place they had seen where the actual effect of the zone was not there. Kushnov saw a simple military truck with a canvas roof with some people inside of it. “Well, our mission is done. Tell your American friends we said hi and good luck.” Artom said. “See you later, good friends.” Kushnov said, stepping into the truck. “Hope all goes well for you all.” Kushnov, Alex, and Kyle got seated as the truck pulled out onto the road. “We will be at the extraction point in 1 hour and 30 minutes.” The driver said. “Get your NVGs on and be ready for any opposition in the air.” “What’s the plan then?” Alex asked. “The plan is to get you guys with all your gear, and some other stuff we were told to get, to the extraction point and wait for a helicopter. After that we’re going to head back to Vyborg.” The man in the passenger seat said. “For now, though, get ready to have to jump out and get in the helicopter fast.” Alex got his HUD on and began to establish a connection with the Artifact satellites so they could communicate with Molly. “Hey there, Molly, we’re currently an hour away from the extract point. Any intelligence updates?” Alex asked. “That’s good; we’ve been watching Russian movement, and it seems they will be launching a large force of five Su-75 Checkmates and a Beriev A-50, which is able to track and search for targets. As long as the helicopter makes it to France, then you’re good. For now, though, just get to the point as fast as possible since

we don't have much time until the group takes off and starts heading your way." "Copy," Alex said. "Report once we make it to Finland." "Alrighty, good luck." Alex disconnected the satellite connection and reported back to the friends. "Seems like we will be pressed for time. The Russians are deploying a group of fighters towards our location, probably because they think we're more than bandits. Anyway, Molly just said to be ready to jump on in." "Sounds good." The driver said, nodding.

The night was very dark, almost pitch black, and the only light was the light that came from the truck. "We're here." The driver said, pulling into a driveway and coming to a stop at a gate. The man in the passenger seat got out and opened the gate. "We have IR lights for the landing pad, so just turn on your NVGs and stay low." Kushnov flipped his NVGs on and adjusted them to his face; without a gas mask, it was much easier for Kushnov to see through the goggles. The truck came to a stop near the gate where they came in, and Kushnov opened the door and got out. It was odd; Kushnov felt like it had only been a few days since he had first dropped into the zone out of that helicopter with the rope. Now he felt like a citizen of the Exclusion Zone. "And here is where our stay closes, in a random field by the border of Russia. How things have changed." Kyle said, looking into the field. "No time to waste being poetic or anything like that now though." Alex said, walking up. "We will have plenty of time to think and reflect on our trip. For now though we haven't even gotten into the helicopter." And like clockwork, the helicopter came into view. It was a stealth Black Hawk with almost no radar signature. The grass in the field was pushed down by the thrust that the helicopter blades were making. It touched down, and Kushnov and Kyle started to drag a large locked case with samples from other missions and from the stores that the bandits had over to the helicopter. The sliding door opened, and an American greeted Kushnov and Kyle. "Good to see you guys." The American yelled. "Just throw the crates and other gear in the back. We'll get you guys seated in after that." "Alright." Kyle yelled, handing the box to the man. "Make sure to tell the other one to quicken up; we have aircraft coming our way, so we can't stay too long." Kushnov nodded. Kushnov ran back and began to grab the rest of the gear. Soon all the gear had been loaded up, and it was time for the three friends to board. "Thank you for the ride." Kushnov said, shaking the two men's hands. "No problem, not only did we get paid, but we also were able to help our American allies. Good voyage back." The driver said, walking away with a wave. The two men went to the outer part of the field and saluted. Kushnov saluted back and got in the helicopter. "We might need some people to operate the guns on the side. Kyle, take the right, and Alex, take the left. Make sure to strap in real well; we can't have you guys fall off if we have to make an evasive maneuver. Kyle and Alex nodded and got in position. "Kushnov, my name's Andrew. I just want you to keep an eye on the gauges in the cockpit." "Sure thing." Kushnov said, starting back for the cockpit. The cockpit was dark, but all the gauges were visible because of the green backlight for everything. "These are

fuel gauges and pressure gauges for the whole system. If any of them go down, other than the fuel gauge, just be sure to tell us.” Andrew said, taking his seat in the co-pilot's seat. “Until then just hang on; it’s going to be a long ride.” “7 hours to be exact,” the pilot said. “And 1303 miles.” “Can a Blackhawk even do that?” Kushnov asked. “Of course, just add a few fuel tanks and you have a perfect flying beast. My name’s Joe, by the way.” “Nice to meet you,” Kushnov said. Kushnov felt the helicopter slowly rise and make a few circles around the field; he could see the truck slowly driving away in the distance. Kushnov felt the helicopter level out and begin its trip to Paris, France.

Chapter 27

Paris, France.

Kushnov saw the five Su-75 Checkmates and the Beriev A-50 slowly coming towards the helicopter on the radar. Although they hadn't actually been found, the AWACS on the Beriev A-50 could get a good signature on the Blackhawk if it got within a few miles of the target, which wouldn't be hard since the Beriev A-50 could go hundreds of miles faster than the Blackhawk. Kushnov looked back out at Kyle and Alex, who were looking out on the wilderness with their NVGs. The scenery was nice, but Kushnov wasn't really concerned about getting a good view; he just didn't want to get shot out of the sky. "Hey Kushnov, unbuckle and go back to Kyle and Alex. Tell them to plug in their intercoms into the helicopter so that they can communicate without yelling." Kushnov got out of his seat and walked back to Kyle and Kushnov. Kushnov plugged in Kyle's headset into the helicopter, and Alex got his in. Kushnov walked back and found his control panel to be blinking red on the top corner. The Beriev A-50 had gotten a lock on the helicopter and now was homing in on it. "Alex and Kyle, please close your doors for now." Joe said on the intercom. Alex pulled his belt-fed machine gun and slid the door closed. Kushnov saw the alert stop and go back to normal. "I hadn't thought of that until now, but I should have told you guys to close the door. At least they didn't get a full lock on us." Andrew said, his mic picking up the sound coming from inside the cockpit. Kushnov sat and looked at his screen, rubbing his eyes every now and then because of the irritating color and dimness. Kushnov looked up and saw Joe looking outside towards the horizon with his HUD on his helmet. The helicopter was slowly making progress, and it began to near the border of Finland. Kushnov saw the Su-75's split up into a group of 3 and then two. The group of two was going top speed straight for the border. "Hey Andrew, we have two Su-75s coming in fast." Kushnov said. "Joe, drop some altitude and hurry up a little. If the Russians deem our retreat into Finland a threat, they will shoot us down. But if we don't seem to be anything to them, then they won't bother shooting at us." Andrew turned on his tablet and watched as the border of Finland closed in. "We will be crossing into Finland in two minutes." Kushnov looked out and saw tall walls on the border; they flew over with ease, and for a moment Kushnov felt safe. That was until he saw the Su-75s on the radar pass the border with them. "They passed, and they have a lock on us." Kushnov said, looking at the display popping up with warnings and other alerts. "Keep cool; it might turn back," Joe said. Kushnov watched as the jets slowed down and honed in on their position; he could tell

they knew there was something there. In a single moment Kushnov could see a missile flare in front of them. “They’re trying to find us with their eyes,” Andrew said. The jets slowed down and slipped to the left of the helicopter. Once the jets had made a full rotation and started coming towards the helicopter, they opened fire. The cannon of the Su-75 spewed lead towards the helicopter as the other Su-75 fired a missile. The missile didn’t have a track, so it slowly fell to the earth. “Kushnov, turn on the countermeasures and turn on the support beacon... Kyle and Alex, you are free to engage.” Andrew said as Joe started to make a roll to lose some altitude. Kushno turned on the beacon, which would call for support from the Finnish Air Force or any other ally assets in the air nearby. Kushnov activated the countermeasures as the sky lit up with flares and smoke. The Blackhawk sank low near the trees as the Su-75s came in for another go. The helicopter diverted the path of bullets and shot back with Alex firing lead at the fighter. The Russian jet sped by with a roar that shook the helicopter. “We have to get moving!” Andrew said. “Go for that highway on the GPS; the Russians wouldn’t try to damage any Finnish property since it would be very problematic.” Joe steered the Blackhawk towards the highway; cars were bustling by, lighting up the road below. The jets came in for another pass and went by not shooting. The Blackhawk hovered over the cars. Kushnov saw some other jets appear on the radar. “We have four jets coming in from Finland,” Kushnov said. “Great, hopefully it’s the Finnish Air Force with their F-35 Lightning IIs,” Andrew responded. Kushnov watched as the F-35s intercepted the Russian Su-75s. “Let’s establish radio contact with the Finnish and make sure they know who we are.” Joe said, turning off stealth mode on the Blackhawk. Kushnov watched as the Su-75s swiftly sped towards the border into Russia; they had made it. The intercom connected to the pilot’s radio. “Thank you guys for taking those Russians off our helicopter.” Andrew said, clicking his mic off. “No problem.” One of the Finnish pilots responded. “Anything to help our American allies... In fact, the US government gave us previous knowledge of the operation and your route, so thankfully we were ready to respond in the specific area. Anywho, you want us to escort you out of Finland?” “Sure, that would be nice.” Joe responded, chiming in. Joe moved the helicopter from a hover into a front pitched angle to create speed. “We lost some fuel due to damage done to our external tanks; thank goodness nothing else, but we might not have enough fuel to make it.” “Sure thing, we could get a low-speed tanker your way and try to get permission to get refueling over the Baltic Sea.” “Sounds good.” Joe started for the Baltic Sea, and Kushnov established connection with the Artifact satellites. The trip was slow, and the F-35s made Kushnov feel like he was in a golf cart. Once the Blackhawk made it to the Baltic Sea, the Finnish called in an MQ-255 Stingray. The MQ-25 Stingray was a drone that had refueling capabilities; it was perfect for the type of job since it didn’t need to give that much fuel, just enough to replace the flight over the Baltic Sea.

“Alright, our mission is done. Good luck, and make sure to report back to the Finnish on the interaction with the Russian aircraft.” The F-35 pilot swerved off just as the sea under the helicopter turned to ground. “Thanks again.” Andrew said, taking his headset off. “That’s why you have allies, Kushnov.” He said, yelling over the helicopter’s noise. The rest of the flight went seamlessly, and before Kushnov knew it, they were flying in Paris, France. The Eiffel Tower was very tall, and the city was full of light; it was the first actually normal city Kushnov had seen in a long time. Kushnov felt safe and ready to touch down on friendly soil. The Blackhawk requested permission to land at the Paris Charles de Gaulle Airport. Once the air traffic had cleared, Joe landed the Blackhawk in the middle of a runway. After the Blackhawk landed, it was trafficked by the French Unimog U5000s, a medium military truck, to a hangar made for top-secret aircraft. Kushnov got out and was greeted by forty to fifty French soldiers and was greeted as a friend. “Welcome to France, good men.” One said. “My name is Alexandre, and I’m here to help you guys get all the stuff from your Blackhawk into the CV-22B Osprey that will be touching down soon. After that you guys will be on your way to America.” “Alright then, let’s start getting the gear off and put it in the back of the trucks.” Andrew said, opening the sliding door and revealing the crates and other things they had gotten in Russia. “All of it?” Alexandre asked. “Yes.” “You guys have quite the load.” Kushnov helped get the cargo out of the helicopter as the rest of them took it over to the trucks. Once the cargo was unloaded and reloaded, Kushnov got in a truck and prepared for the flight that was to come. To Kushnov’s surprise, they didn’t go straight to the Osprey but went to another hangar. “Why are we going to the hangar?” Alex asked. “We want to get all the cargo on pallets so we can just push them in; hopefully it will all fit.” A French man said. Kushnov took a break and went outside; it was cool but not cold—very nice weather, actually. Kushnov saw two ospreys come in for landing. They touched down with ease, and Kushnov was surprised to see the Ospreys taxi over to the hangar. Kushnov ran back inside and found some forklifts picking the gear all up and starting for the Ospreys. Once the aircraft had been loaded with everything, they boarded the first Osprey. Kushnov got strapped into the cargo hold on a collapsible seat and sat there. He could hear the engines taxi out, and before long the whole aircraft lifted up and began to hover above the ground; it was quite the experience. Kushnov looked out the window and saw Paris disappear and the water slowly take away the mainland’s view; they were going straight to America and wouldn’t make a stop until they made it to America.

Chapter 28

Back In America.

The Osprey had been flying for 15 hours over the ocean, and since it was running low on fuel, an air tanker came out to refuel it. The process took almost no time at all, and the Osprey continued on, bound for Arnold Air Force Base. Kushnov watched as the sun rose over the ocean. It was a cool orange, and the overall color was stunning. Kushnov fell asleep; he hadn't slept for real in 24-plus hours and was tired. Once Kushnov woke up, he could see the mainland. He didn't know where they were, but after only a few more hours he could see the base they would be landing at. The landing was simple and straightforward, and Kushnov and the rest of the crew that had come to the base were shuffled into an airport bus to a C-17 Globemaster III that would take all the people, pilots, and cargo to Fairchild Air Force Base in Washington, where their trip would end. Kushnov's time at Arnold AFB was short, and he was soon inside the large C-17 on his way to Washington. Kushnov sat and tried to rest as the long flight continued, and once they got to Fairchild AFB, the three were put into a van to be taken to Seattle. Kushnov reflected on his mission in Russia. The losing of Dimitri and the trip inside Zone 3032 were still fresh in his mind.

Once they arrived in Seattle, the three friends were each given a room in the tall Artifact tower; it was the main complex where all the operations and meetings were conducted. Kushnov was led to his room and was given civilian clothes and a set of clothes for the upcoming meeting. Kushnov slept for a long time. Once Kushnov got up, he was given breakfast and met up with Kyle and Alex. "We're back, and now our mission is done." Kyle said, excited. "I'm very happy to be back." Kushnov said. "The memories and things we did in the zone will forever be implanted in my mind." Alex said, getting up. "Let's get going; we have a large meeting to attend on the top floor. It's about the mission. Don't worry, Kushnov, I will represent us in the meeting if needed." "Thanks." The three got up and made their way to the elevator. Kushnov thought of how odd it was seeing people walking around with files and other random business things. Once they had made their way to the top floor, they were led into a large room overlooking Seattle with a large table in the middle. The whole floor was made just for meetings, and security guards were posted in the two entrances. The whole room was open and full of people sitting in nice swivel chairs. At one end was the CEO of Artifact, Greg Farlin; right next to him was Jack Martin and other representatives from Camp

Vostok. On the other end was a computer with a large TV and a webcam with the president on it. All the seats had a microphone for talking so the president could hear what was going on and being said. Kushnov sat down next to Jack Martin's team and looked around. Molly was there and waved to Kushnov and his friends. Good to know people I recognize are here, he thought as he waved back, smiling.

Greg Farlin rose and addressed the people. "As you all know, our team from Russia has returned from their mission." He said, looking at the three friends. Alex, Kushnov, and Kyle rose and greeted everyone and then sat down again. "The mission in many ways was a success. They returned with lots of intelligence and data, not only about Zone 3032 but about the whole zone in general. My scientists are currently reviewing all the data that they brought back and will be ready to give a report on the tests and other stuff, not regarding the people and operations in the zone, but the normal nature and life inside the zone very soon." He sat down. "We have gotten some news, though, that will complicate things very much." He continued. "It appears some activity other than the known is going on in Zone 3032. From what we have learned, the Russians have planted a base inside the zone that is underground, a large complex to be exact. We will, like I said, be ready to give a full report very soon, but right now we are not sure what exactly our next course of action will be. We hope the Russians do not suspect our presence in the zone, and hopefully we can maintain peaceful relations with them. But this unknown presence inside the zone is very concerning. Thankfully Kyle Wolfgang was able to collect lots of photos of the complex and even 3D scans. Alex was able to collect some samples that they had in crates, and it seems Kushnov was able to get them out of the complex with all the data and samples. The exact dimensions of the complex are unknown other than the part that the three went through, but we know enough to suppose it is possibly conducting very dangerous tests and operations. The people operating it were clearly from the Sparta and Scorpions groups, but we concluded that other nations could have very likely been working there too. So until then we would recommend we keep this private, of course, and hopefully we can analyze the data and draw some conclusions. Good job again, men." Greg said, addressing the three friends. "You guys have perfectly succeeded in your mission with the best of results. I personally can't thank you enough." Greg ended. The president spoke up. "I am very distressed to hear this, but I will take to mind the facts. Hopefully in the future we can still maintain our ties with Russia as an ally." "Agreed." A British representative said. "This unknown presence, in my opinion, if you wish to hear, Mr. President, would explain a lot of activity and odd things we have seen in the past. Hopefully we can make use of the data to better explain problems we have been having." The British representative ended. "I would like to ask a question if I may." An agent from Washington, DC, said. "Are there any plans of going back to Russia?" "No." A lady from Artifact said. "That would be very dangerous; we only took the risk to go to Russia because we thought it was not

inhabited by Russian soldiers. The fact that they are there means that our presence is really not wanted. Thus we would be fools to launch another secret mission there. Maybe if the Russians offered, we would, but it has too many risks.” “That answers my question.” The man said, writing something down in his notebook. “Well, if we don’t have any more questions, then our meeting is done. Thank you, Mr. President, for attending to the best of your abilities, and thank you all for coming. This has turned into a very important matter, and until we are done analyzing the data, we cannot technically confirm or deny anything; thus, I would prefer you not focus on the subject until our next meeting. You are dismissed.” Greg said. The whole room got up, and the people got in lines to shake hands with the three friends. Once the room had mostly emptied, Greg came over to congratulate the three. “You guys did a great job; you, in fact, succeeded to our expectations. The mission was a great success, and I hope you understand how important and impactful it was. For now you guys will have to stay under guard and in the complex until we take any actions or make any plans. Until the next meeting, have a good day.”

Greg left the room, and the three stood in the room with a guard near them. “You’re free to go wherever you wish in the building.” The guard said. “You want to eat lunch, Kushnov?” Kyle asked. Both Alex and Kyle were hungry. “I would, but I’ll meet you down there.” “Alrighty, see you there.” Kyle and Alex left for the cafe floor. “Can you take me to the top?” Kushnov asked the guard. “Sure, wherever you want.” Kushnov and the guard got into the elevator and went to the top floor. Kushnov got out and saw the Artifact helicopter that the people came in and out on. Kushnov went to the railing and looked out into the horizon. The air was fresh, and it smelled good. “Smells like freedom,” Kushnov said. The guard nodded. “Well, we can go now.” Kushnov walked over towards the elevator and pressed the button to enter. It felt great being in America again.

Chapter 29

The Aftermath.

“Ladies and Gentlemen.” The spokesperson for Artifact said, walking up onto the stage. “Let me please introduce you to our CEO of Artifact, Greg Farlin.” The whole room clapped. Greg walked onto the platform and began his speech. “Thank you all for being here. The great value of the unity of Europe is very important, and I’m happy to know everything is going very well.” The room, being full of presidents and very important government people, quieted. “I have good news and bad news to bring to you today, and also just normal news.” The tension in the room rose. “Today marks the founding of the UEN, the United European Nations. The founding of this group has helped establish peace among all superpowers. Russia is now an ally with many countries, including America, because of it. It would be an understatement to say that the UEN is important.” Greg gave a pause. “As you know, located in Russia is the Exclusion Zone. Some try to argue it’s not real, while others argue otherwise. We have recently concluded that the actual danger of the zone to our interests is great. The bandits who preside there, although nice, are threatened by not only the government but also the actual zone. The zone in general is very dangerous, and according to intel, we have concluded that we should close the whole zone off. Now, I know Russia has made great efforts to close the zone and evacuate the citizens of Russia to safer places, but I think it should be a joint effort, a common mission, that we should all try to contain the zone and eventually destroy it. Now I do not think we should inhabit it; that is wrong. It is clearly Russia’s land and territory. But I think we should better seal the borders and send help when it is needed to respond and take back the land from the creatures and bandits. In conclusion, I think we should help Russia fight this beast and destroy it off the face of the earth. It would be of benefit to the UEN and, hopefully, make that part of Russia inhabitable once again. That is all I have for now, though.” The people clapped as Greg got off the stage. Why didn’t I tell the truth? It’s too dangerous to have the Russians operating secretly in the zone. The threat will stay until someone uncovers it. Greg thought. For another time. He reassured himself.

Kushnov watched on television as the newscaster reported on the meeting. “One day, someone else is going to figure it out,” Kushnov said, turning the TV off with a click of a button. “For now, it’s not anyone’s business, though.” Alex said. “It’s not of any

benefit to bring it up to the world. For now, we will maintain secrecy.” Kyle said. “For now.” Kushnov mumbled, rubbing his eyes because of the strain of the TV screen. Kushnov looked out the window over Seattle. They had been in the Artifact building for a month now, and they had only gotten to visit their families once. It was good, though, and Kushnov didn’t hate the place. But it was the reason they were still there that he hated. Russia was unwilling to talk about any possible operations in the zone with America, and so, just to make sure, the three were made to stay because of security reasons. It wasn't that they were not trusted, but they might be needed anytime, and since they were the firsthand reporters of the Zone, they would be needed if it became public news. For now, though, Kushnov sat and looked outside. His mission was not done; maybe the mission in Russia was, but the zone still stood frozen in time, unaffected by politics and the world. “Maybe someday Russia will admit its presence. But until then, we're going to have to wait and see.” Kushnov said. “I'm going to go to the office.” “See you later then,” Kyle said.

Kushnov walked up the stairs to the office. Although it was the very top floor, it was still easy for Kushnov to walk upstairs. Once Kushnov got there, he entered Greg's office. Greg had given Kushnov access to his office for a space where he could sit and do whatever he pleased. Kushnov, most of the time, wrote papers about his time inside the zone for the scientists. But this time we went to look at a paper Artifact had published to its workers and the top-level people about the statue Kushnov had cut off inside the zone. The statue was a much-debated topic inside Artifact. Some people supposed it to be an idol of some sort, others a secret statue of a cult-like society. Kushnov had his own thoughts on it. But it was clear that it was very unique compared to other statues around the world. Kushnov closed the laptop and sat in Greg's chair. It was a very nice office. He swiveled the chair so that he could look out into the city. He could see the mountains in the distance, covered in snow and trees. Kushnov liked America, and he missed Alaska. But for now, he would have to be content with being in a tall building, just out of reach of the vast wilderness of the Pacific Northwest. “I think man still does have natural instincts; perhaps we really just wish to live in the wild, half-natural and half-man-made world. Either way, we sure do like to stick our noses in other people's business.” Kushnov said out loud. It was all going to be alright.

Glossary

Sparta Group

A top-level Russian government-based organization tasked with protecting the Exclusion Zone from unauthorized personnel. They provide security for the Scorpion scientists in Zone 3032 and take care of all government transportation within the zone.

Scorpion

A Russian scientific corporation of elite government-funded researchers. Scorpion works in the Exclusion Zone and more specifically, Zone 3032. They conduct secret experiments and research.

Artifact Incorporation

A top-secret private American company. This group includes both scientists and security forces and is responsible for top-secret missions and research within the Exclusion Zone and other closed-off places.

UEN (United European Nations)

An alliance of mostly European countries unified for the purpose of the safety of Europe and its allies.

AWACS (Airborne Warning and Control System)

An airborne radar system used for surveillance. It tracks aerial threats from long distances.

NVG (Night Vision Goggles)

Wearable devices that allow the user to see in dark conditions by amplifying ambient light or through infrared light.

HUD (Heads-Up Display)

A transparent display that projects crucial data directly into the user's face.

GPS (Global Positioning System)

A satellite-based navigation system that gives location and time information anywhere on Earth. GPS is used for navigation, tracking, and targeting.

INS (Inertial Navigation System) A navigation method that uses internal sensors (gyroscopes and accelerometers) to calculate position, velocity, and orientation without having to have a GPS connection.

EHF (Extremely High Frequency)

A radio frequency range (30 to 300 GHz) is used for high-speed communication.

LiDAR (Light Detection and Ranging)

A remote sensing technology that uses laser pulses to measure distances and generate precise 3D maps of areas.

LASAMS (Land-Based Surface-to-Air Missile Systems)

Ground-deployed missile platforms are designed to detect, track, and destroy enemy aircraft or incoming missiles.